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Inequality and Racial Backlash: Evidence from the Reconstruction Era and the Freedmen's Bureau[†]

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How do majority groups respond to narrowing inequality in racially polarized environments? We study this by examining the Freedmen's Bureau, an agency created after the US Civil War to aid former slaves and launch institutional reform in the South. Using new historical records and an event-study approach, we estimate the bureau's impact on political, social, and economic outcomes. Vote shares for Democrats, the party that previously championed slavery and opposed Black civil rights, initially eroded in bureau counties, but these impacts faded as federal oversight weakened. Racial backlash emerged rapidly and persisted, suggesting White majorities sought to offset Black progress. (*JEL* D63, D72, J15, N31, N41)

> The slave went free; stood a brief moment in the sun; then moved back again toward slavery.
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> —W. E. B. Du Bois in *Black Reconstruction in America* (1935)

Nearly four million formerly enslaved Black Americans faced a daunting transition from slavery to freedom at the conclusion of the US Civil War. The vast majority were landless and many had life experiences largely confined to the plantations and farms in which they were held in bondage. Moreover, newly emancipated Black Americans, dubbed freedmen, lived in Southern communities where many Whites held prejudiced attitudes and resented the full rights of citizenship secured for Black individuals by the Northern victory.

In response to these challenges, the Republican Congress passed legislation in 1865 that created the Freedmen's Bureau as an institution to provide material aid

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throughout the South and broadly promote the independence of formerly enslaved populations. Du Bois (1903, p. 10) described the Freedmen's Bureau as "one of the most singular and interesting of the attempts made by a great nation to grapple with vast problems of race and social condition." In addition to distributing food rations and providing medical care, the bureau opened schools for Black children, worked toward the creation of a free labor market, and supported the political enfranchisement of Black Americans before its operations ended in 1872. Historical scholarship over the last century has generated little consensus on whether the bureau had any material effect (Foner 2014) largely due to data limitations and a lack of clear empirical benchmarks.

This paper examines the short and long-run impacts of the Freedmen's Bureau on social progress and racial backlash using an array of novel and preexisting data sources. First, we compile a list of the locations of the bureau's field offices that operated in selected Southern counties using newly available records from the National Archives. This provides us with a measure of the intensity of exposure to the Freedmen's Bureau's policies that is motivated by historical narratives which suggest proximity had important impacts on the extent to which the bureau could assist newly freed Black Americans (Mugleston and Hopkins 1978; Rodrigue 2001). Second, we combine the location of field offices with county-level measures of voting as well as historical records on Black voter registration and office holding during the Reconstruction era. The combined data allow us to analyze important measures of social progress for Black Americans. Third, we test for potential backlash by studying violence against Black Americans using canonical measures of lynching analyzed in prior work, recently compiled records on attacks against African-American schools, newly digitized bureau records on crimes against Black Americans, and an original collection of newspaper-based measures of county-level violence.

While the data available for our study is comprehensive, an additional challenge confronting our goal of assessing the Freedmen's Bureau is concern over the selective nature in which field office locations were chosen during the Reconstruction era. The bureau was tasked with establishing offices in an environment with tight time and budgetary constraints—pressures that were intensified by the urgency and uncertainty faced by an occupying federal government in a post-war context. As a result, the bureau was unable to place field offices in all in-need areas. Existing reviews of archival records highlight that officials often prioritized selecting towns and cities for offices based on their transportation infrastructure and the size of their Black population (Bean 2016). In line with these accounts, we show that counties with field offices were more likely to have railroad lines and a larger Black population in the prewar years. These patterns imply that naive comparisons of counties with and without bureau offices might not isolate differences in the intensity of exposure to bureau services if the factors driving office selection were correlated with the propensity for political engagement or racial violence in local communities.

To address concerns over selection in our analysis, we follow recent scholarship that identifies suitable comparison counties using a historically-motivated matching-based approach (e.g., Dippel and Heblich 2021). We show that a limited set of demographic and transportation-related county characteristics identifies a set of comparison counties that are well balanced not only on a broader set of

non-targeted 1860 characteristics, but also on changes in characteristics from 1850 to 1860. Moreover, our event-study approach that compares electoral outcomes over time yields two additional pieces of evidence on the validity of our research design. First, we use the matched sample and find no evidence of differential pre-trends before 1860 in a standard event-study specification. Second, our matching-based approach yields results for political outcomes that are very similar to those obtained when including county fixed effects to control for time-invariant, unobserved characteristics of counties.

Counties exposed to the bureau experienced political progress that emerged immediately. Event-study estimates reveal that the vote share for Democrats decreased by 5 percentage points in the 1868 presidential election in counties exposed to bureau field offices. There is an equal-in-magnitude increase in the Republican vote share. These results are consistent with Black political empowerment given that the Republican Party was the major political force that supported civic rights for Black individuals during this period. As additional measures of short-term political progress, we study whether the bureau influenced Black voter registration rates from 1867–1869 for state constitutional conventions and the number of Black civic officeholders, who mostly entered office before 1872. We find evidence of quantitatively important, positive effects: Having a bureau office increased the Black voter registration rate by nearly 13 percentage points (17 percent relative to the mean level for counties without a bureau office) and almost tripled the number of local Black officeholders within a county. These impacts are consistent with early-century historical scholarship emphasizing that the bureau may have fostered Black political empowerment by regulating elections and supporting important political organizations such as the Union League (Peirce 1904; Taylor 1926; Du Bois 1935; Bentley 1955).

However, the political progress facilitated by the bureau did not last. The effects on Democratic and Republican vote shares reached their peak in 1868, and subsequently dissipated until the effects were negligible by the late 1880s. This elimination of the effect of the bureau occurs as the bureau's activities were curtailed, the federal government exercised less oversight of the South, and Southern states enacted Jim Crow voting restrictions such as literacy tests and poll taxes (Kousser 1974).

Given the evidence on political impacts, we next turn to consider the effects of the bureau on racial violence. The Reconstruction era has long been recognized as a period of intense racial conflict, particularly as an effort to politically intimidate Black Americans (Wells 1892, 1895; Du Bois 1903; Raper 1933). Most prominently, this period witnessed the emergence of the Ku Klux Klan, a White supremacist group that sought to launch a "reign of terror" on freedmen and undermine Republican political leaders of both races in the South. Our focus is on testing whether the bureau—potentially due to its impacts on Black empowerment—amplified rates of violence against Black individuals using a range of newly available data sources.

We find widespread evidence that direct exposure to bureau offices increased racial violence in the years following the establishment of the bureau. As an initial approach, we rely on a novel annual county-level measure of newspaper reports of lynchings before and after the end of the Civil War. Using the within-county variation through an event-study approach, we find increases in lynching reports

in treated counties in the years following the establishment of the bureau. We also study additional measures of violence and racial intimidation that are only observed after the creation of the bureau. This analysis reveals that counties treated with field offices had more Black lynchings, more executions of Black individuals, and experienced a higher number of attacks on Black schools—a key institution that threatened antebellum norms (Woodson 1919).

Our analysis concludes with two exercises that examine long-run measures of racial backlash in the twentieth century and study potential mechanisms that may drive the bureau's impacts. First, we find that counties with historical bureau field office exposure have higher amounts of racially motivated killings from 1930–1955, more institutional racial violence in the form of executions of Black individuals from 1900–2003, higher amounts of second-wave and third-wave Ku Klux Klan activity (around 1915 and 1960, respectively), and a larger number of monuments built to honor the Confederacy. In sum, the bureau's impacts on political outcomes were short-lived, but the large effects on racial violence were not. Second, as one key test of mechanisms, we study county-level outcomes measured in census data using our event-study framework. Most notably, there are positive impacts on school attendance and literacy rates of children, important measures of Black progress given the relatively high rates of illiteracy and limited educational access for Black Americans at the turn of the century.

Throughout our analysis, we address several possible confounds. A primary concern is that federal troops occupied parts of the South until 1877, which raises the possibility that our results could be explained by federal troops being located in the same counties as the Freedmen's Bureau. We address this concern using recently available data on the historical positions of troops (Downs 2015a). While there is a positive correlation between a county having a bureau field office and the number of troops, this association is modest (correlation coefficient: 0.18). Moreover, we show that our estimated effects of bureau field offices are essentially unchanged after augmenting our specification to control for the number of troops in a county. These exercises rule out the most immediate concern of omitted variable bias, though the many connections between the Freedmen's Bureau and the army in terms of staffing and operations imply that these two organizations had closely linked effects. We take a similar approach to address the Freedman's Savings Bank, a distinct Reconstruction era institution, and find that our results are robust to controlling for bank branch presence (Celerier and Tak 2024).

Overall, this paper most broadly contributes to the literature on institutions and responses to attempts at institutional reform (Acemoglu and Robinson 2006, 2008; Martinez-Bravo, Mukherjee, and Stegmann 2017; Dell, Lane, and Querubin 2018). We provide comprehensive quantitative evidence of the effects of the Freedmen's Bureau—an agency endowed with both resources and broad legal authority to reform important social and economic relationships in the immediate aftermath of the US Civil War. Our results provide unique empirical evidence that is consistent with theoretical models that highlight the persistence of long-established institutions despite fundamental changes in the political environment (Acemoglu and Robinson 2008) and related predictions from frameworks that stress backlash by majority groups in a racially stratified environment (Darity 2022). In this way, our analysis creates new connections between modern political economy research and historical scholarship

on the Reconstruction era that has largely relied on qualitative arguments to characterize the bureau's impacts (e.g., Du Bois 1903, 1935; Foner 2014; Litwack 1980; Peirce 1904).

Our work also contributes to an emerging literature studying Black progress and racial animus in US history (e.g., Sacerdote 2005; Naidu 2010; Cook 2014; Logan 2020a, 2023; Aneja and Xu 2022; Ang 2023b; Jones and Schmick 2023; Hornbeck and Logan 2023; Frieden, Grossman, and Lowery 2024; Althoff and Reichardt 2024).[1] Broadly, our findings for the Freedmen's Bureau are closely related to contemporaneous work by Testa and Williams (2023) which provides evidence that Black lynchings increased notably when Democrats narrowly lost elections during the Reconstruction period. Collectively, the findings from Testa and Williams (2023) and our results provide some of the first credible evidence on the origins of racial violence in the aftermath of the Civil War. Relative to their analysis, we innovate by providing evidence on how the creation of the Freedmen's Bureau and its positive impacts on Black empowerment may have had the unintended consequence of increasing violence during the Reconstruction era due to White backlash.

Finally, this paper connects with a large literature on how historical institutions can have long-lasting legacies (Nunn 2009). Closely related to our work are studies providing evidence that present-day Black and White voting behavior can be traced back to historical experiences with slavery and racial violence (Acharya, Blackwell, and Sen 2016; Williams, Logan, and Hardy 2021; Williams 2022). Relative to this work, our findings highlight that a sizable portion of twentieth century racial violence can be traced to long-lasting backlash to a short-lived policy.

I. The Freedmen's Bureau and Potential Effects

A. *Historical Background*

After four years of fighting to preserve the Union and end slavery, Northern leaders turned their focus in 1865 to the task of rebuilding the South. Republicans in Congress and abolitionist groups were especially concerned with the challenges facing four million former slaves. The daunting tasks confronted by policymakers included the creation of a new economic system in which Black Americans were free workers and a new social system in which Black Americans were free from violence. The hostility and violence that freedmen faced throughout this period underscored the need for a broad federal intervention.[2]

President Abraham Lincoln signed legislation establishing the Freedmen's Bureau, formally known as the Bureau of Refugees, Freedmen, and Abandoned Lands, a month before Confederate General Robert E. Lee surrendered in Appomattox, Virginia (US Congress 1865). Created as a division of the War Department, the law endowed the bureau with a broad mission to provide aid to former slaves while also

[1] Our work also relates to an emerging set of findings on more contemporary backlash against social policy (Abdelgadir and Fouka 2020; Ang 2019; Bernini, Facchini, Tabellini, and Testa 2023; Fouka 2020; Wheaton 2022).

[2] Violence and incidents of racial intimidation arose from economic disputes and the assertion of White supremacy (Foner 2014). For example, according to a Freedmen's Bureau report from 1866, a White man in Grayson County, Texas, shot and killed a Black man, Jack Stone, for failing to tip his hat (US Bureau of Refugees, Freedmen, and Abandoned Lands 1866).

managing lands abandoned throughout the South. To lead the bureau, Lincoln called on Major General Oliver Otis Howard, a man with close ties to freedmen aid societies in the North (Foner 2014). After his successful appointment, Howard staffed the bureau largely by relying on military officers to serve as his assistant commissioners and local agents.[3] The bureau legally operated during 1865–1872, although funding cuts largely reduced its operations as of January 1869.[4]

The Freedmen's Bureau undertook a range of operations to support its goal of improving the economic and social standing of Black Americans. The bureau distributed millions of food rations and provided medical care to hundreds of thousands of patients (Du Bois 1903; Lieberman 1994).[5] In addition, the bureau actively attempted to reform and create new institutions in the South. Bureau officials worked to establish a free labor market by overseeing contracts and resolving disputes between planters and freedmen.[6] Promoting Black education by supporting the opening of thousands of Black schools—many of which continued after the bureau closed—was also a major priority. At its high point in 1870, nearly 150,000 Black children were enrolled in bureau schools (Du Bois 1935).

The bureau also was active in supporting the Black civil and legal rights created by Congress in the late 1860s. To be readmitted to the Union, the first Reconstruction Act of 1867 required each former Confederate state to adopt a new constitution that guaranteed enfranchisement of Black men (US Congress 1867). This legislation stipulated that Black men had the right to vote in the election of delegates to the conventions that wrote these constitutions. Officials of the Freedmen's Bureau took important steps to enforce these provisions of the Reconstruction Act. Bureau agents advised newly enfranchised Black individuals and promised them protection (Du Bois 1935).[7,8] Moreover, bureau officials often served on voting boards that were tasked with visiting each electoral precinct and registering eligible voters (Peirce 1904).

The bureau opened field offices throughout the South to execute its operations and provide assistance to freedmen. A key challenge facing the bureau was a lack of sufficient resources to open offices in all locations where freedmen needed relief. With respect to choosing office sites, General Otis Howard wrote, "it was impossible at the outset to do more than lay down a *few general principles* to guide the officers assigned as assistant commissioners [emphasis in italics added here and below]" (Howard 1908, p. 363).

[3] Supplemental Appendix C provides details on total annual expenditures for the bureau and personnel, while also highlighting the challenge of quantifying the extent of resources and staffing from these official sources.

[4] The Freedmen's Bureau was distinct from the Freedman's Savings Bank, which was a government-sponsored private bank that grew to have 37 branches, including several in the North, before its collapse in 1874 (Stein and Yannelis 2020; Celerier and Tak 2024). It is also distinct from refugee camps that existed during the Civil War (Ramos-Toro 2024).

[5] Each ration was meant to serve one person for a week. An estimated one-third of these rations were provided to White individuals.

[6] Historians have at times noted that some bureau agents were susceptible to the influence of White landowners and served their interests over those of freedmen (Litwack 1980).

[7] Supplemental Appendix Figure A1 is an example of the official instructions that bureau officers received regarding their orders to support political participation of freedmen in 1867.

[8] The bureau was widely recognized as having a role providing protection to freedmen. Supplemental Appendix Figure A2 is an illustration from Harper's Weekly discussing the bureau in 1868. The image depicts a bureau agent standing between crowds of White and Black Americans.

Existing reviews of the bureau's archives highlight that officials often selected towns and cities to maximize impacts of relief and reform efforts. As a result, officials prioritized areas with large Black populations and those that could be easily accessed by train or other modes of transportation. For example, Bean (2016) notes that bureau authorities "assigned SACs [subassistant commissioners] to places of *greatest need or importance*," while other agents also "had assignments at the *main hubs for shipments* of crops to market from the interior," and the "remaining SACs received appointments to regions with *large black populations*."[9] Accessibility was a key consideration given that freedmen often traveled to field offices to seek help mediating labor disputes or protection from violence (Foner 2014). In addition, bureau agents worked out of these offices to oversee local government officials and planters and to coordinate with charities and service organizations such as the American Missionary Association (AMA) and the Union League (Peirce 1904; Du Bois 1935; Bentley 1955; Richardson 1999).

B. *The Potential Political and Social Effects of the Freedmen's Bureau*

The potential political and social effects of the bureau depend on how the Black and White communities in the South responded to its relief and reform efforts. On the one hand, the bureau's efforts to register and protect Black voters should have promoted political engagement. This channel implies the bureau should have increased support for the Republican Party, which was aligned with the abolition cause in the antebellum period and Black civil rights in the subsequent Reconstruction era. On the other hand, the responses of the White community may have blunted or reversed any gains by Republicans in the South for at least two reasons. First, recent theories of political change predict that elites may use their wealth and influence (i.e., forms of de facto political power) to counter reforms that expand legal and civil rights to new groups (Acemoglu and Robinson 2006, 2008). Second, existing frameworks for understanding intergroup inequality (Darity 2022) and rank preferences (Kuziemko, Buell, Reich, and Norton 2014) suggest that this type of opposition could emerge not only from elites, but also from a broader group of individuals who oppose a narrowing of economic and social disparities. Any of these factors would predict that the bureau may have indirectly increased support for the Democratic Party, which campaigned against Black rights during Reconstruction, while also unintendedly raising levels of violence experienced by Black communities.

The broad historical narrative surrounding Reconstruction suggests that the opposing effects of the bureau on Black empowerment and White backlash are plausible. As noted by Du Bois (1935) and Foner (2014), the Black community embraced their new voting rights created through the Reconstruction Acts. In this environment, anecdotal evidence suggests bureau agents had clear demand for their efforts to educate and protect freedmen in the voting process. Historical accounts also emphasize how the advancement of Black individuals could threaten the

[9] Bean (2016) summarizes, "Bureau headquarters required the office to be in a *convenient and accessible* location. Many men established their offices at the *county seat or most important city* in their subdistrict. In districts comprising more than one county, however, the office was in the *most populous* and important county in the district."

"public and psychological wage" that White individuals received (Du Bois 1935).[10] Consistent with this interpretation, a large contingent of the White community worked to undermine Black social and political progress during the Reconstruction era. Notably, state legislatures in the South passed laws known as the Black Codes which sought to ensure that freedmen remained employed in agriculture at low wages.[11] Moreover, the Ku Klux Klan (KKK) emerged during the Reconstruction era and launched a violent terror campaign throughout the South. Congressional testimony from witnesses and victims highlights that the Klan's violence had political motivations and sought to intimidate Republican politicians, their allies, and Black voters in general (US Congress 1872).

While the general historical record suggests the bureau could have had potential impacts on political and social outcomes, the lack of detailed data on its performance and operations within states has prevented rigorous empirical evaluation. Instead, a large body of Reconstruction and Freedmen's Bureau historical scholarship has offered mixed assessments based on distinct and hard-to-reconcile qualitative approaches. For example, early literature was often critical of the bureau's effectiveness based on selective accounts of the partisan interests of some bureau agents (e.g., Bentley 1955). In contrast, Du Bois (1935) and some later scholars offered more optimistic assessments. Our study aims to provide clarity in debates over the bureau by providing a comprehensive analysis of its effects on political and social outcomes based on explicit quantitative comparisons and benchmarks.

II. Data

Our analysis is based on the creation of county-level samples that combine information from archival records of the Freedmen's Bureau with data on political outcomes, violence committed against Black Americans, and county characteristics measured in the US Decennial Census. The county-level samples rely on available data for all states that comprised the Confederate States of America except for South Carolina (which does not have relevant election data prior to the Civil War).[12] This section provides details on the sources of these data. We map all variables for our analysis to 1900 county boundaries and harmonize county-level longitudinal outcomes using the crosswalks provided by Ferrara, Testa, and Zhou (2024). The samples for some outcomes of interest vary due to differences in data coverage, as explained in Supplemental Appendix B.1.

Freedmen's Bureau Field Offices: Information on the presence of Freedmen's Bureau field offices comes from records made available by the National Archives.

[10] With respect to status, Du Bois (1935) noted that "white groups of laborers, while they received a low wage, were compensated in part by a sort of public and psychological wage. They were given public deference and titles of courtesy because they were white" (p. 700) and, "every problem of labor advance in the South was skillfully turned by demagogues into a matter of inter-racial jealousy" (p. 701).

[11] Specific provisions initially passed by some states required Black individuals to sign year-long employment contracts, imposed fines on employers who offered work to an individual already under contract, and prevented Black individuals from renting land in urban areas (Foner 2014). See also Naidu (2010).

[12] Since South Carolina cannot be analyzed in our political analysis, we also exclude South Carolina counties from the main analysis of other outcomes for consistency. Our main conclusions do not change when we include South Carolina in the sample (Supplemental Appendix Table A10).

Records from bureau state offices provide details on the location of each field office. Supplemental Appendix Table B1 provides a detailed list of the microfilm records that are the underlying basis of information on county field offices. Field offices were located in the states that comprised the Confederate States of America as well as DC, Kentucky, Maryland, and West Virginia. We focus on the former Confederate states because the institutional and political environments in these states were substantially different than in the other states with a field office.[13]

National Elections: We study the effects of the Freedmen's Bureau on political outcomes using data on presidential and congressional elections from 1840–1900. The earlier elections in this window cover a period when slavery was a key issue prior to both the Civil War and the establishment of the Freedmen's Bureau. Our analysis examines elections through the year 1900 to cover the period following the traditional dating of the end of the Reconstruction era in 1877 (Foner 2014). All county-level election data come from Clubb, Flanigan, and Zingale (2006). Our first main election outcome is the share of votes cast for the Democratic Party presidential candidate, as Democrats were the major political party that supported slavery as an institution in the South and the Democratic Party existed throughout the entirety of this period.[14] The second main election outcome that we study is the Republican vote share beginning with 1856, the first presidential election after the party was founded by anti-slavery politicians and activists.[15] As secondary outcomes, we also study Democratic and Republican vote shares for Congress. Our analysis does not include South Carolina since the state legislature chose representatives for the Electoral College and there was no popular vote for presidential elections prior to the Civil War (Grodzins and Moss 2024). Note that county-level elections are not defined for years in which the county did not participate in a given election. This selectively occurs during the Reconstruction era in the election years when former Confederate states had not yet been readmitted to the Union.

Black Political Outcomes: Information on Black voter registration and the election of Black politicians during the Reconstruction era is available from two historical sources. Hume and Gough (2008) is the source of county-level Black voter registration for the period 1867–1869. We construct the voter registration rate by dividing these county-level registration totals by one-fourth of the total 1860 Black population (to account for the fact that only adult men could vote at this time).[16]

[13] We explored a separate analysis of Freedmen's Bureau field offices in the few states outside of the former Confederacy. However, the resulting sample size was much smaller and our matching approach did not yield treatment and control counties that are well balanced.

[14] In the 1860 election, Stephen Douglas was the candidate of the Democratic Party, and John Breckinridge was the candidate of the Southern Democratic Party. The latter received a larger share of votes in the South, and we combine the two vote shares for our analysis.

[15] In 1856, the Republican Party presidential candidate, John Fremont, received a small share of Southern votes. Instead, the main opposition to the Democratic Party in the South was the Know Nothing Party. Abraham Lincoln received an even smaller share of Southern votes in 1860, when the main opposition to the Democratic Party in the South was the Constitutional Union Party. As a robustness test, we estimate our main event-study regression (described below) when using vote shares for these alternate parties in 1856 and 1860.

[16] We include both free and enslaved Black individuals in constructing total Black population in 1860. Our use of one-fourth as an adjustment factor is motivated by statistics from the 1860 census, in which 26 percent of free Black individuals were men age 18 and above.

Foner (1996) provides individual-level information on Black officeholders during the Reconstruction era. Officeholders included in the data typically hold positions as a state house representative although the data include others who held a range of positions including aldermen or judges. Over 80 percent of Black politicians in these data entered office in or before 1872, the final year before the bureau was abolished. Using the information on each official's location of service, we construct a county-level count of the number of Black officials. The data from Hume and Gough (2008) and Foner (1996) were obtained from the Logan (2020b) ICPSR replication files.

Annual Reports of Lynchings: We create an original annual county-level measure of the frequency of lynchings reported in newspapers from the newspapers.com database. Our approach follows recent historical studies such as Testa and Williams (2023), Masera, Rosenberg, and Walker (2022), and Ottinger and Winkler (2022) to create annual measures of newspaper content. We link each newspaper to its county using information on historical counties from the Census Place Project (Berkes, Karger, and Nencka 2023). For a given county and year, we count the total number of pages that include the word "lynching" across all newspapers. Using this total, we define a lynching rate by dividing by the total number of newspaper pages for the given county in that year. Our analysis sample is a county-level panel covering the period January 1, 1860 through December 31, 1899. Supplemental Appendix B.2 provides more detail on the construction of this measure, including examples shown in Supplemental Appendix Figure B1.

Confirmed Black Lynchings: Data on confirmed Black lynching cases comes from the Historical American Lynching Data Collection Project (Project HAL; Hines and Steelwater 2006) and Seguin and Rigby (2019a, b). These data contain individual-level information on lynching cases including the location of the crime and the race of the victim.[17] The earliest lynching in the data occurred in 1882, and the latest lynching occurred in 1936. Based on these data, we create a county-level measure of all lynchings that occurred from 1882 to 1900 to align with the period covered in our analysis of elections.

Black Executions: Data on executions of Black individuals performed under civil authority (i.e., death penalties) come from Espy and Smykla (2016). The data includes the county of conviction which we use to geolocate the decision. This data has also been used by Grosjean, Masera, and Yousaf (2023) as a measure of institutional racial violence.[18] We aggregate executions of Black individuals from 1865 to the end of 1899 for our short-run analysis and from 1900 to the end of 2002 for the long-run analysis.

[17] As stated on the Project HAL site, they follow the NAACP definition of lynching, which requires that (i) there must be evidence that someone was killed; (ii) the killing must have occurred illegally; (iii) three or more persons must have taken part in the killing; and (iv) the killers must have claimed to be serving justice or tradition.

[18] Tolnay and Beck (1995) note that, "Statistics on legal executions in the South clearly indicate that Blacks were especially vulnerable to the death penalty. Raper even refers to the state-sanctioned execution of Blacks as "legal lynchings"—a sentiment echoed by Harry S. Truman's Committee on Civil Rights. In the majority of cases, the formal justice system dealt harshly enough with African-Americans accused of crimes to satisfy the punitive interests of most whites. Sometimes mobs took lynch victims from police custody, however, often after conviction. Clearly, Whites lynched even after the wheels of justice had begun to grind."

Attacks on Black Institutions: Scribner (2020a, b) provides reports of 574 attacks on Black schools in former slaveholding states during the Reconstruction era.[19] Information on these attacks was collected based on original reviews of newspaper reports, published findings from a congressional committee investigating the rise of the first Ku Klux Klan, and records from the Freedmen's Bureau. We construct a county-level measure of all such attacks that occurred during the Reconstruction era. The data cover attacks that occurred between 1865 and 1878. We create a single measure for each county of the total number of attacks on Black schools during this period.

Freedmen's Bureau Records on Violence: We create a novel dataset of crimes reported by Freedmen's Bureau officers and agents in their regular reports from 1865 to 1868. The vast majority of the reported crimes were committed against Black individuals. The underlying sources for the data are records from the National Archives' holdings for the Freedmen's Bureau. The format of the original report is a tabular or narrative description of murders or other violent crime committed (commonly referred to as an "outrage"). We used a combination of automated and manual data collection and review steps to standardize and create tabular versions of these data. The main outcome of interest is the total number of outrages reported by the Freedmen's Bureau in each county. Supplemental Appendix B.3 provides additional details on our data processing and the original microfilm record.

Census, Transportation, Bank, and Army Data: Our analysis uses a variety of measures from Census Bureau data. We construct county-level measures of total Black population from 1850 to 1900 using complete count census data (Ruggles et al. 2024a, b) for the free Black population and county tabulations of census data (Manson et al. 2023) of the slave population for 1850 and 1860. We also use the complete count census data to construct measures of the shares of Black individuals age 5–19 who are attending school or are literate.[20,21] Data from Haines (2010) provide the number of 1860 residents that are a slave, a free Black individual, a White individual, and living in an urban area. The data from Atack (2016) and Atack (2015) allow us to identify whether each county had a railroad in operation as of 1865 and the distance between the geographic centroid of each county and the nearest steamboat-navigated river as of 1865, respectively. We obtain data on Freedman's Savings Bank branch locations from Celerier and Tak (2024) who source these from digitized registers on FamilySearch.org. We also use archival-based data from Downs (2015b) to measure the median number of Union troops in a county between 1865–1872.

Long-Run Outcomes: We use seven categories of long-run outcomes. First, we use newly compiled measures of racially motivated killings of African Americans from 1930 to 1955. These data were produced by the Civil Rights and Restorative Justice Project (CRRJ) at Northeastern University School of Law (the Burnham-Nobles

[19] We drop a handful of attacks recorded as occurring during Civil War years.
[20] For 1850 and 1860, we assume that no slaves attended school or were literate.
[21] The original 1890 census records were destroyed in a fire so we cannot use individual-level data to create a measure of school attendance or literacy in this year.

CRRJ Archive 2023).[22] In total, they capture 973 well-documented killings. Second, we use executions of Black individuals from 1900 to the end of 2002 (Espy and Smykla 2016). Third, we use data on locations of the second KKK. These data come from Ang (2023a, b) which sources it from Kneebone and Torres (2015). Based on Klan records and publications, the dataset includes the location of a chapter (known as a "klavern") and the year (ranging from 1915 to 1942) each chapter was first mentioned. Fourth, we use data on locations of the third KKK from Ang (2023a, b), which he sources from Mazumder's (2018a, b) compilation of locations of active klaverns noted in House Un-American Activities Committee reports. Fifth, we use data on the presence of Confederate monuments from the Southern Poverty Law Center's "Whose Heritage?" database, which includes 2,292 monuments in the former Confederate states that have latitudes and longitudes. Of these, roughly half note the year of dedication, ranging from the 1800s to 2021 (mean: 1915, median: 1926). Finally, our sixth and seventh measures are sourced from the Opportunity Atlas (Chetty et al. 2018). We study upward mobility as the later-life rank in the nationwide income distribution for children in the 1978–1983 birth cohorts whose parents were in the twenty-fifth percentile of the nationwide income distribution—this is measured using IRS administrative records on income from 2014–2015 (when the respective cohorts were aged 31–37). We also study incarceration (based on the 2010 census short form).

III. Empirical Strategy

This section describes the empirical approaches that we use to understand the effects of direct exposure to the Freedmen's Bureau. Our strategies rely on identifying a comparison group of counties that were not "treated" with a bureau field office but had otherwise similar characteristics. Based on accounts of the priorities for bureau office placement, we create a historically-informed matched sample of comparison counties using a limited set of 1860 characteristics. As a validation exercise, we report results using the matched sample that demonstrate balance on un-targeted 1860 characteristics and 1850–1860 trends. For our main analysis, we use event-study models for outcomes that are measurable before and after the bureau existed and cross-sectional models for outcomes that are only measurable afterwards. The remainder of this section provides further details on our approaches.

A. *Identifying a Comparison Group of Counties*

Figure 1 illustrates the cross-county variation in our main sample by providing a map of the 341 counties that had at least one field office during the bureau's existence and the remaining 543 counties without offices.[23] As noted in Section I, the

[22] The CRRJ notes, "In most incidents, but not all, the killings also conform to the prevailing NAACP definition of lynchings earlier discussed. In some cases, the perpetrator(s) are unknown; and in others, fewer than three known perpetrators are involved." The data includes deaths at the hands of law enforcement, though there is some ambiguity around the inclusion of these cases in the NAACP's adopted lynching definition.

[23] The vast majority (93.6 percent) of treated counties have a single field office. For completeness, Supplemental Appendix Figure A3 displays an analogous figure without imposing our baseline restriction that all counties have non-missing data for 1860 presidential election vote shares, which notably adds South Carolina.

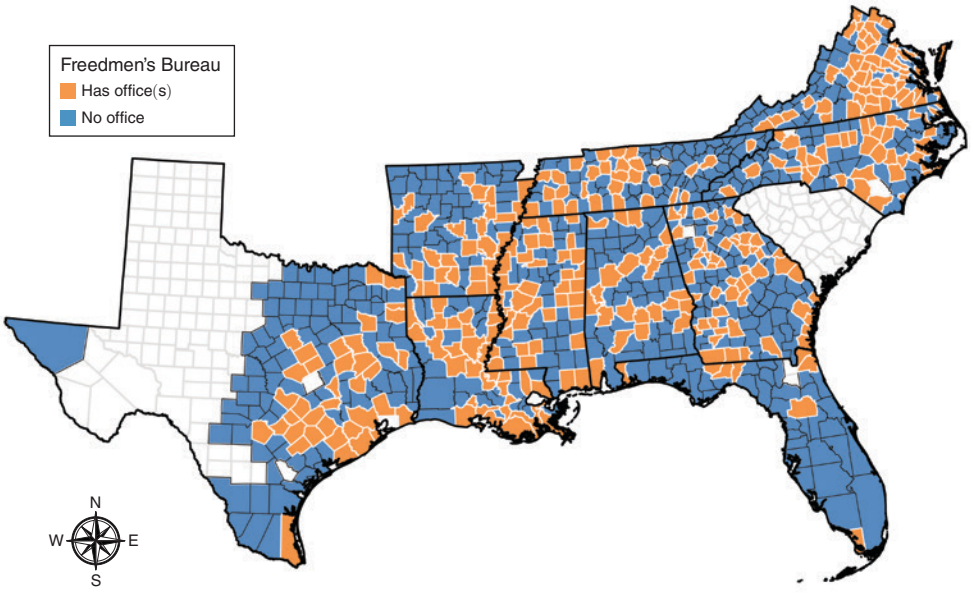


FIGURE 1. MAP OF FREEDMEN'S BUREAU FIELD OFFICES, MAIN SAMPLE

Notes: This map shows historical (1900) counties in the 11 Southern states that formed the Confederate States of America. Counties included in our election sample are shaded. Counties that had at least one Freedmen's Bureau field office are colored in orange shading, while blue shading indicates that the county had no offices. All counties in South Carolina are excluded from our election sample since there were no popular elections held prior to the Civil War. We exclude many counties in the western portion of Texas because a single sparsely populated county (Bexar) encompassed essentially all of this land during parts of the nineteenth century and county-level election data are not available for this area.

bureau was created in the aftermath of the Civil War and prioritized establishing its field offices in areas where they could have the most impact. However, many communities where freedmen could have benefited from relief were not selected due to the limited budget and resources available to the bureau. The key to our research design is to identify a comparison group of counties that met the bureau's priorities for placement but were not chosen to host a field office.

Table 1 compares characteristics from the 1860 census for the counties treated with exposure to the Freedmen's Bureau field offices and various samples of counties that were not directly exposed. The statistics in columns 1 and 2 show that there are important differences in the county-level averages between the counties that had a bureau field office and the remaining Confederate counties that did not. In line with the historical record noted in Section I, the summary statistics show that counties with bureau offices had larger populations, particularly with respect to the size of the Black population, and better transportation access. To facilitate the comparison of counties, columns 3 and 4 report the raw difference and an adjusted difference that accounts for state fixed effects. Overall, the large contrasts between these groups of counties highlight the difficulty inherent in any evaluation of the effects of exposure to the bureau. Basic comparisons of the political and social outcomes of counties that did and did not have a field office may reflect both the impact of the bureau *and* important differences in other preexisting county characteristics.

Table 1—Summary Statistics and Covariate Balance

	Treated mean (1)	Control mean (2)	Treated − control difference (3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Panel A. Core controls						
log White population	8.51	8.16	0.35	0.31	0.13	−0.02
			(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.03)
log slave population	8.23	6.89	1.33	1.14	0.59	0.02
			(0.09)	(0.08)	(0.07)	(0.04)
log free Black population	3.43	2.31	1.11	0.73	0.51	0.00
			(0.15)	(0.09)	(0.10)	(0.05)
Black population share	0.46	0.28	0.17	0.14	0.09	0.01
			(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)
log urban population	1.13	0.32	0.81	0.79	0.66	−0.17
			(0.17)	(0.18)	(0.19)	(0.16)
Has railroad line	0.58	0.26	0.32	0.30	0.25	−0.01
			(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.01)
Distance to nearest river (km)	18.9	35.0	−16.2	−12.5	−5.2	0.9
			(2.8)	(2.5)	(2.3)	(0.9)
Panel B. Additional characteristics						
log total population	9.19	8.54	0.65	0.55	0.30	0.01
			(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.04)	(0.03)
log Black population	8.28	6.93	1.35	1.15	0.61	0.03
			(0.09)	(0.08)	(0.07)	(0.03)
log foreign population	4.20	3.13	1.08	1.09	0.80	0.16
			(0.11)	(0.10)	(0.11)	(0.11)
Slave population share	0.44	0.28	0.16	0.14	0.09	0.01
			(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)
Free Black population share	0.017	0.008	0.009	0.005	0.004	0.001
			(0.002)	(0.001)	(0.002)	(0.002)
Urban population share	0.055	0.012	0.043	0.043	0.040	0.003
			(0.010)	(0.010)	(0.010)	(0.013)
Foreign population share	0.023	0.025	−0.001	0.004	0.009	0.003
			(0.005)	(0.004)	(0.004)	(0.004)
log farm value	14.34	13.35	0.98	0.78	0.35	−0.03
			(0.11)	(0.10)	(0.09)	(0.08)
log number of large farms	1.42	0.73	0.69	0.56	0.41	−0.01
			(0.07)	(0.07)	(0.07)	(0.06)
log agricultural output	13.08	12.05	1.03	0.83	0.33	−0.05
			(0.12)	(0.10)	(0.09)	(0.07)
log cotton output	9.88	8.51	1.37	1.78	0.83	0.34
			(0.33)	(0.23)	(0.23)	(0.26)
log manufacturing output	10.29	8.90	1.39	1.18	0.64	−0.34
			(0.27)	(0.26)	(0.28)	(0.27)

(*continued*)

To address concerns over the selective nature of bureau field office placement, our empirical approaches rely on a matching-based approach that is motivated by historical narratives on bureau operations and supported by evidence in the data. This approach focuses on a set of seven core controls listed in panel A of Table 1 that are chosen based on the bureau's demographic and transportation-related priorities for the location of field offices. For demographics, we include measures of the size of the slave and free Black population as well as the Black population share in

Table 1—Summary Statistics and Covariate Balance (*continued*)

	Treated mean (1)	Control mean (2)	Treated − control difference (3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Manufacturing output share	0.21	0.17	0.03	0.04	0.03	−0.01
			(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.02)
Churches per 1,000 people	1.80	2.31	−0.50	−0.48	−0.44	−0.08
			(0.08)	(0.08)	(0.08)	(0.06)
Democratic vote share	54.3	55.0	−0.7	−2.9	−1.8	0.2
			(1.3)	(1.0)	(1.0)	(1.0)
State fixed effects	–	–	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
Matched sample	–	–	No	No	Yes	Yes
Reweighted	–	–	No	No	No	Yes
Counties	341	543	884	884	699	699

Notes: This table shows means and differences in means for 1860 characteristics of counties. Column 1 shows means for treated counties that had at least one Freedmen's Bureau field office, while column 2 shows this for control counties with no office. Columns 3 to 6 report coefficients from regressions of the characteristic on a treatment indicator, with heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors in parentheses. Column 3 reports the simple difference (i.e., OLS with no controls), column 4 reports the coefficient from a specification including state fixed effects, column 5 runs this regression using just the matched sample, and finally column 6 layers on the inverse propensity score weighting. Panel A is composed of the core control variables upon which the propensity score matching is based, while panel B includes additional control variables that are not included in the matching set.

the pre-bureau period using the 1860 census. This accounts for the fact that bureau officials wanted to concentrate their aid and reform efforts in areas where there was greater demand for relief. We also include the size of a county's White and urban populations to account for the fact that the bureau prioritized existing population centers to facilitate oversight of local officials and collaboration with charitable groups serving freedmen. Finally, we include two proxies for transportation conditions in counties: whether a county had access to an active rail line and the distance between each county's centroid and the nearest river. These account for the fact that agents chose locations to facilitate transportation with other government officials, volunteers from the North, and aid.

We use the core controls to construct a matched sample of similar counties with (treated) and without (control) bureau field offices. The matched sample is created using a propensity score estimated from a logit regression of the bureau treatment indicator, FB_c, on the set of seven core bureau office selection variables. We always match counties in the same state. Using the propensity score, we determine the set of control counties by matching (with replacement) each treated county to its five nearest neighbors in propensity score space. Panels A and B of Figure 2 display the estimated propensity score in the full and matched samples and illustrate how the matching process reshapes the distributions of the estimated treatment probabilities.

The evidence in the remaining columns of Table 1 shows that using the matched sample and reweighting based solely on the core controls improves balance results notably. Column 5 demonstrates the importance of selecting suitable comparisons by showing that the magnitude of the treatment-control difference decreases when balance is assessed on the sample of matched counties. Importantly, the results in

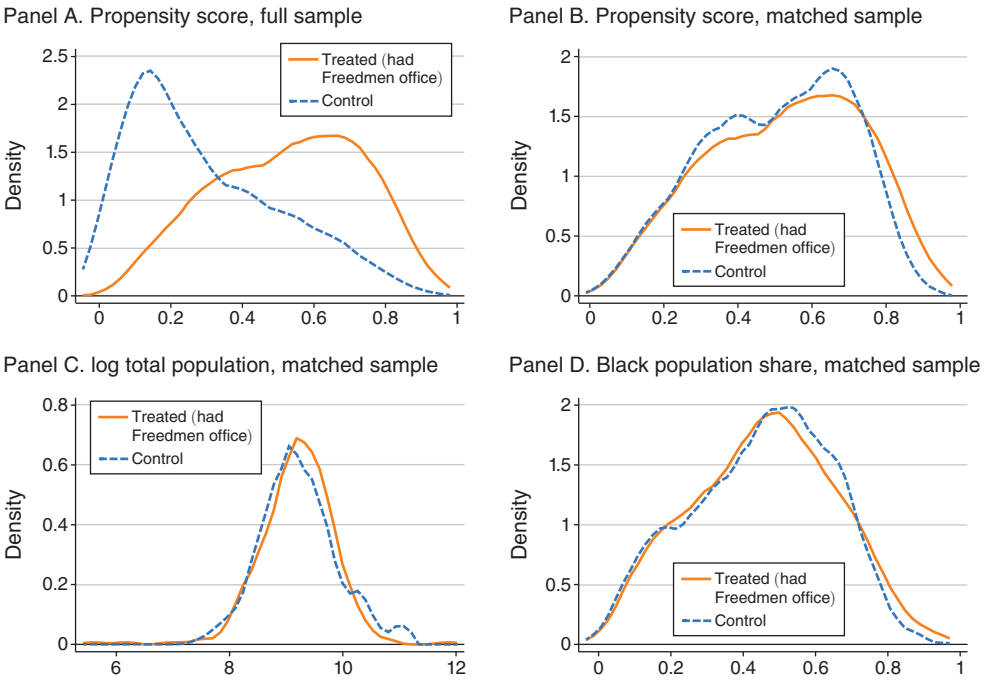


FIGURE 2. DENSITY PLOTS OF PROPENSITY SCORES AND KEY CHARACTERISTICS

Notes: This figure presents kernel density plots of key variables for treated counties that had Freedmen's Bureau field offices (in solid orange) and control counties that did not have an office (in dashed blue). Panels A and B present plots of the propensity scores separately for the raw and matched samples of counties, respectively. The propensity scores are estimated from a logit regression of the bureau treatment indicator, FB_c, on the set of core bureau office selection variables listed in Table 1, panel A. Using the propensity score, we determine the set of control counties by matching (with replacement) each treated county to its five nearest neighbors in propensity score space. All matching is conducted within each state in our sample. Panels C and D present kernel density plots using the matched sample for the log of total population and Black population shares, respectively. These are weighted using the ATT weights constructed from a logit regression of a county having a Freedmen's Bureau field office on state fixed effects and the core controls.

column 6 show that remaining differences shrink further in magnitude and lose statistical significance after reweighting based *only* on the core demographic and infrastructure-related measures. The results for the additional county-level characteristics listed in panel B are particularly notable as differences for economic and political characteristics that are not directly related to the core control variables are no longer significant as well.

Moreover, panels C and D of Figure 2 show that the matched treated and control counties are similar in terms of the distribution of log population and the Black population share—not just at the means. We also find that the distributions of several other key baseline variables—distance to the nearest river, urban population share, share of output from manufacturing, churches per capita, and Democratic vote share—are very similar between the matched treated and control counties (Supplemental Appendix Figure A4). Finally, we show that there are no significant differences in the changes of key demographic variables from 1850 to 1860 after reweighting in Supplemental Appendix Table A1.

B. *Event-Study Specification*

We use an event-study approach to study outcomes that are measurable both before and after the establishment of the Freedmen's Bureau. Motivated by the institutional context and results in Table 1, we implement this approach using the sample of counties matched based on 1860 characteristics. This choice eliminates counties with treatment propensity scores based on the core controls outside of the region of common support. In other words, our event-study analysis estimates the effects of bureau exposure by examining changes in outcomes over time between treatment and comparable control units.

Formally, we estimate the following model that allows us to examine the evolution of relative outcomes while controlling for fixed differences across counties and broader time trends:

$$(1)\quad Y_{c,t} = \sum_{j \in \mathcal{T}^{Pre}} \pi_j FB_c \times 1\{t = j\} + \sum_{j \in \mathcal{T}^{Post}} \gamma_j FB_c \times 1\{t = j\} + X_c^{1860}\beta_t + \delta_{s(c),t} + \alpha_c + \epsilon_{c,t},$$

where $Y_{c,t}$ is the outcome of interest for county c in year t. The variable FB_c is an indicator for whether county c had a Freedmen's Bureau field office and $1\{t = j\}$ is an indicator for year t being equal to the index value j. The index sets $\mathcal{T}^{Pre}$ and $\mathcal{T}^{Post}$ denote the years before and after the establishment of the bureau, respectively. The years included in these sets vary based on the outcome variable (e.g., elections occur every four years). The vector X_c^{1860} consists of the core controls in panel A of Table 1. We allow the coefficients on these controls to vary over time to allow for the possibility that outcomes evolved differently over time in counties with different characteristics. We also include state-by-year fixed effects, $\delta_{s(c),t}$, to focus on within-state comparisons of treated and control counties, and the model includes a county fixed effect, α_c, to absorb time-invariant differences across counties. The error term is denoted by $\epsilon_{c,t}$. We weight all results based on equation (1) using the average treatment-on-the-treated (ATT) weight.[24] For inference, we use and report heteroskedasticity robust standard errors clustered at the county level.

The main parameters of interest, π_j and γ_j, are the coefficients on the indicators for treatment by relative time terms. For each outcome, we set the reference year by excluding from each regression the term for the closest year before the bureau was created. For example, in our analysis of presidential elections, the omitted reference period for all counties is 1860 as this is the final election which occurred before the creation of the bureau. Our setup implies the estimates of π_j and γ_j represent the difference in an outcome between year j and the reference period for treated counties relative to that of the same difference over time among matched control counties.[25]

[24] The ATT weight is equal to 1 for treated counties. For control counties, the weight is equal to $\hat{p}/(1-\hat{p})$, where $\hat{p}$ is the propensity score constructed from a logit regression of a county having a Freedmen's Bureau field office on state fixed effects and the core controls. In some specifications, we add a vector of time-varying control variables to assess robustness.

[25] Because our measure of treatment is non-staggered, our event-study and difference-in-difference estimates do not require the adjustments that may be necessary with staggered treatments (Roth, Sant'Anna, Bilinski, and Poe 2023).

Estimates of γ_j represent the reduced form impact of being treated with greater exposure to the bureau as measured by the presence of a field office. If bureau offices served surrounding areas extensively, then the difference in outcomes between counties with and without offices would be muted, and estimates of γ_j will be biased toward zero. In principle, services could extend beyond the counties hosting offices because the jurisdiction of the bureau field staff typically spanned multiple nearby counties. However, the prevailing historical narrative implies that the bureau plausibly had the greatest impact on the communities closest to its field offices. For example, freedmen often approached their local field office to report assaults or seek protection from violence (Foner 2014). Moreover, bureau reports often noted that Black workers often would seek mediation and dispute unfair labor practices by directly appealing to bureau field agents at their offices (e.g., Mugleston and Hopkins 1978; Rodrigue 2001). At the same time, traveling to even adjacent counties represented a considerable effort for freedmen due to high transportation costs and a lack of safety (Elliott 1952; May 1968; Bean 2016).

Notably, two features of our approach allow us to address the potential concern that differential trends affect the interpretation of our comparisons. First, our reliance on the matched sample ensures that we are comparing counties with similar 1860 characteristics. This potentially reduces the scope for differential trends between counties with and without field offices (Miller 2023). Second, the estimates of π_j from the event study provide a natural falsification test. For example, if political outcomes were evolving similarly in treated and the matched control counties, we would expect the estimates of π_j to be small and not statistically significant. A caveat for this analysis is that political outcomes before 1860 may reflect different underlying dynamics than those after the Civil War given the changing political role of race and slavery, although the event-study comparison still identifies relative differences between treated and control counties.

While the event-study results are a key focus, we also summarize results using flexible difference-in-difference specifications where the main independent variables of interest are interactions between the Freedmen's Bureau field office indicator, FB_c, and broad time indicators. For example, in our analysis of political outcomes, we group together years 1868–1872 and 1873–1900 to pool the effects in these periods. The choice of time periods in the difference-in-difference models is based on the dynamic pattern of effects that we document in the event-study specification.

C. *Cross-Sectional Specification*

A number of important outcomes can only be observed in the period following the Civil War and the establishment of bureau offices. For example, Black enfranchisement began in 1867 (two years after the bureau's founding) and crimes against freedmen reported to bureau agents are only available starting in 1865. To consider these outcomes, we rely on cross-sectional comparisons between counties with and without bureau field offices.

Our preferred cross-sectional approach also relies on the matched sample which eliminates counties without bureau offices that had treatment propensity scores (based on the core controls) outside of the region of common support. Using this sample, we estimate reduced-form impacts by regressing a given outcome on FB_c,

the indicator for the presence of a bureau field office. Based on the patterns observed in Table 1, we use an inverse probability weighting and 1860 covariate regression adjustment to estimate the treatment on the treated effect.[26] We use the core controls listed in panel A of Table 1 and state fixed effects for propensity score estimation and regression adjustment in our main specification. All standard errors based on this approach are heteroskedasticity-robust.

A natural concern for our matching approach is that the core controls and state fixed effects might be insufficient to fully account for unobserved, time-invariant differences between counties with and without bureau field offices. To shed light on this issue, we conduct sensitivity analysis using our event-study specifications. Specifically, we examine whether estimates of π_j and γ_j change meaningfully when we exclude county fixed effects from the model. In the event study, these county fixed effects absorb all time-invariant differences across counties. Such differences would be a key source of potential bias that could threaten comparisons between counties with and without bureau field offices for outcomes that we do not observe prior to the establishment of the bureau. Of course, a limitation of this robustness check is that it is only feasible for outcomes which are observed before and after the bureau was constructed. As a result, we also explore the robustness of our cross-sectional specification to including 1860 characteristics beyond those in panel A of Table 1.

IV. Results: Political Progress

In this section, we present estimates of the effects of the Freedmen's Bureau on a range of political outcomes. We find that exposure to the bureau led to gains in the Republican vote share in presidential and congressional elections, increases in the Black voter registration rate, and gains in the number of Black officeholders. These results suggest that the bureau notably improved the political power of Black individuals in the short-term. However, we find evidence of these gains vanishing alongside the end of Reconstruction.

A. *Elections*

We begin by presenting a graphical summary of the impacts of Freedmen's Bureau office locations on election outcomes. Figure 3 reports event-study estimates of equation (1) for presidential elections spanning 1840 to 1900. As discussed in Section IIIB, these results are based on the matched sample, and each point estimate reflects the treatment-control difference between a given election year's vote share and the omitted reference year, which is the last pre-Civil War election in 1860.[27]

[26] This approach features the "doubly-robust" property of consistency under correct specification of either the model for the conditional mean of the outcome variable or the propensity score (e.g., Bang and Robins 2005).

[27] Note that the 1864 election is omitted from event time due to the Civil War and secession of the Confederate states that make up our sample. Since the Freedmen's Bureau was created in 1865, the first posttreatment election is 1868 for the states that participated in this election (Mississippi, Texas, and Virginia had not yet reentered the Union at this time). Our event-study estimates are similar when excluding these states from all years of the analysis.

Panel A shows results for the Democratic vote share, for which we have five pretreatment elections (1840 to 1856), while panel B shows the Republican vote share, with the sole pretreatment year corresponding to the first presidential election (1856) after the party's founding by anti-slavery activists in 1854.[28] Our main results are based on equation (1) and appear as a thick black line. Reassuringly, the results show no evidence of pre-trends, with all coefficients being small and statistically insignificant.

In the first posttreatment election of 1868, we see a significant decrease in the Democratic Party vote share (5 percentage points) in counties with a Freedmen's Bureau office, relative to the comparison group. We also see a corresponding increase in the Republican Party vote share of a similar amount. These changes attenuate starting with the 1872 election, when most of the Freedmen's Bureau operations were curtailed, and are small and indistinguishable from zero by 1892. Underlying these event-study effects is an increase in the Democratic vote share between 1860 and 1868 in control counties and a slight decrease in counties with a bureau field office. The Democratic vote share fell in both sets of counties in the 1872 election that Ulysses S. Grant won by a large margin, then increased over time and converged—consistent with the fade-out of the event-study impacts (Supplemental Appendix Figure A5).

Table 2 presents difference-in-difference estimates for presidential and congressional elections. Motivated by the results in Figure 3, we combine the elections from 1868 to 1872 that had sizable negative point estimates for the Democratic vote share into an earlier period and the elections from 1873 to 1900 that had point estimates closer to zero into a later period. Column 1 of Table 2 shows that Bureau exposure results in a 4.0 percentage point drop in Democratic presidential vote shares on average from 1868–1872. This corresponds to a 7 percent drop in this vote share relative to the matched control group mean (61 percent). The decrease in the Democratic vote share in congressional elections, shown in column 2, is similar, at 3.2 percentage points. As with the event-study, the results in columns 3 and 4 for the Republican vote share have the opposite sign and a similar magnitude. We estimate an increase in the Republican vote share of 3.4 percentage points (12 percent) for presidential elections and 2.3 percentage points (10 percent) for congressional elections. Together, these results suggest that the Freedmen's Bureau generated immediate electoral gains for Republicans and corresponding losses for Democrats.[29]

The estimates for elections from 1873 to 1900 are small and indistinguishable from zero.[30] This period includes the implementation of poll taxes, literacy tests, and other forms of Black voter suppression under state-level Jim Crow legislation. These state laws drove Black voter participation rates close to zero, which would

[28] As previewed in Section II, the vote shares for Republican presidential candidates in the South were low in the 1856 and 1860 elections. As a robustness exercise, we combine the Know Nothing and Constitutional Union Party vote shares with the Republican Party vote shares in these elections and estimate our event-study model. These results are similar to our main estimates. We do not do this as our main analysis due to the substantial differences in these parties' platforms.

[29] We find similar estimated impacts of exposure to the bureau on gubernatorial elections (Supplemental Appendix Table A2), although the available data for these elections have important limitations relative to the data used for presidential and congressional elections.

[30] We find a similar pattern of no detectable impacts in the elections after 1900 (Supplemental Appendix Figure A10).

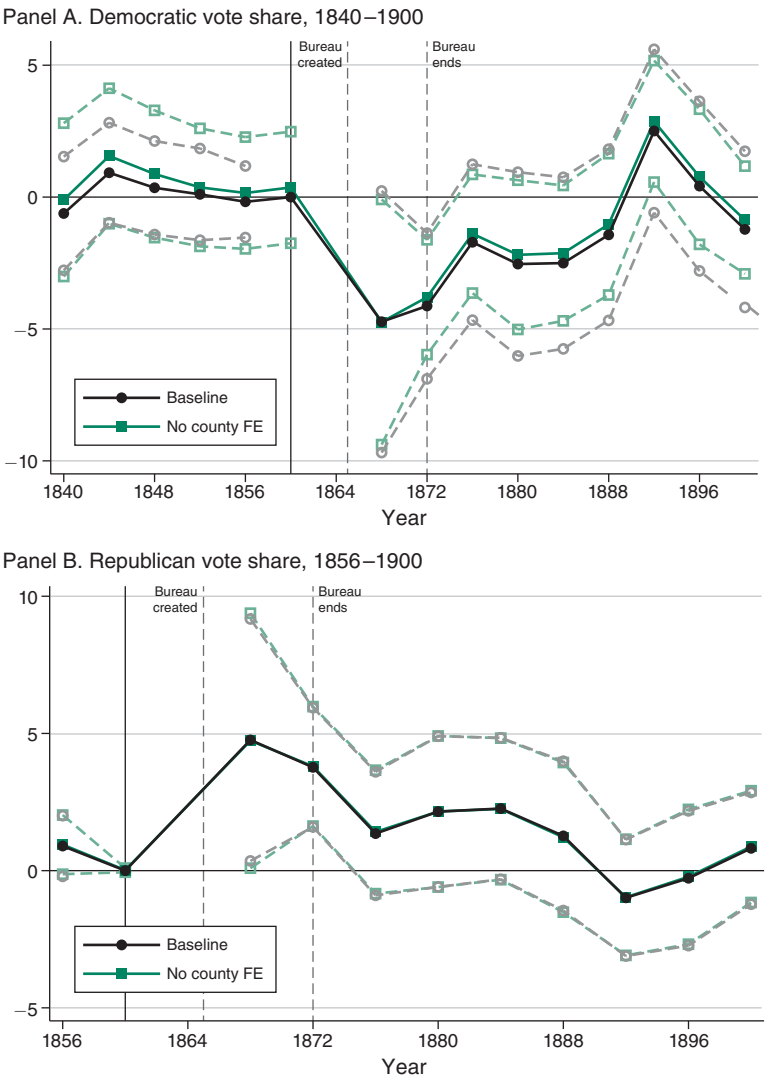


FIGURE 3. IMPACTS ON PRESIDENTIAL VOTE SHARES, EVENT STUDY ESTIMATES

Notes: Panels A and B report event-study estimates of the impacts of having at least one Freedmen's Bureau field office on county-level presidential Democratic and Republican Party vote shares, respectively. The baseline results are based on a regression that includes interactions between the county having any Freedmen's Bureau field office and year indicators, interactions between year indicators and state indicators, interactions between year indicators and the core controls listed in panel A of Table 1, and county fixed effects. The omitted reference year is 1860. The figure also shows results from a specification in which county fixed effects are excluded and there is no omitted reference year. All regressions are weighted by the ATT weights constructed from a logit regression of a county having a Freedmen's Bureau field office on state fixed effects and the core controls. There are no Republican vote shares before 1856 since the party was not formed until 1854. The sample is the set of elections for states that formed the Confederacy (excluding South Carolina due to its lack of a popular vote prior to the Civil War). The 1864 election is not included due to the Civil War and secession of Confederate states. The dashed lines surrounding the point estimates represent the 95 percent confidence interval based on standard errors clustered at the county level.

have increased the Democratic vote share relative to its value in the early 1870s.[31] Ultimately, while the Freedmen's Bureau offices increased the relative standing of

[31] For example, the number of Black registered voters in Louisiana dropped from 130,344 in 1896 to 5,320 in 1900 after the enactment of the disfranchising code in that state (Lewinson 1932, p. 81).

Table 2—Impacts on Elections, Difference-in-Difference Estimates

	Democratic		Republican	
	President	Congress	President	Congress
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Post 1868–1872 × 1(Freedmen Office)	−4.0	−3.2	3.4	2.3
	(1.5)	(1.7)	(1.3)	(1.2)
Post 1873–1900 × 1(Freedmen Office)	−0.7	−2.5	0.5	0.9
	(1.3)	(1.9)	(1.0)	(1.0)
Control mean	61.4	59.6	28.3	23.0
R^2	0.48	0.49	0.71	0.42
Observations	7,381	11,794	7,381	11,794
County FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: This table reports estimates from a difference-in-difference specification in which vote shares are regressed on interactions between the county having any Freedmen's Bureau field office and indicators for being in a posttreatment period (split into 1868 to 1872 and 1873 to 1900), interactions between these period indicators and state fixed effects, interactions between these period indicators and the core controls listed in panel A of Table 1, and county fixed effects. Regressions are weighted by the ATT weights constructed from a logit regression of a county having a Freedmen's Bureau field office on state fixed effects and the core controls. Columns 1 and 3 report vote shares for nine post-period presidential elections (1868, 1872, 1876, 1880, 1884, 1888, 1892, 1896, 1900), where the pre-period encompasses the 1856 and 1860 elections. Columns 2 and 4 report results for posttreatment congressional elections (every two years from 1868 to 1900) with pretreatment elections being 1856 and 1858. Control mean is calculated over all years. Robust standard errors clustered at the county level are reported in parentheses.

the Republican Party in these treated counties, this change could not be sustained and was eroded alongside the reduction of federal oversight in the South.

As previewed above, we also report results in Figure 3 that shed light on potential concerns for a cross-sectional approach to estimating impacts of bureau exposure. Notably, we find that the estimated impacts of bureau exposure are very similar in a version of equation (1) that omits county fixed effects (green line with square markers). This result suggests that the historically-motivated variables we use to identify comparable control counties adequately account for unobserved, time-invariant characteristics of counties.

B. *Black Political Participation and Representation*

We next examine impacts on measures of Black political participation and representation. As described in Section I, part of the bureau's duties included assisting in voter registration and election oversight. As such, if the Freedmen's Bureau was more successful in protecting the voting rights of newly enfranchised freedmen in treated counties, then we should see an increase in Black voter registration. The bureau also could have increased Black voter registration through its broader efforts, which might have increased Black men's civic engagement or perception of safety. Because Black men did not vote or hold political office in the South before the establishment of the bureau, we use the cross-sectional approach described in Section IIIC for this analysis.

The results in Table 3, panel A indicate that the Freedmen's Bureau increased the Black voter registration rate. As a benchmark, column 1 reports results from an OLS regression that uses the full sample and controls for state fixed effects and the core control variables listed in Table 1, panel A. We find that the Freedmen's Bureau

Table 3—Impacts on Black Political Outcomes, OLS and Matched Sample Estimates

	(1)	(2)	(3)
Panel A. Black voter registration rate			
1(Freedmen Office)	0.18	0.13	0.13
	(0.04)	(0.03)	(0.03)
Control mean	0.76	0.77	0.77
R^2	0.20	0.30	0.34
Observations	778	625	625
Panel B. Number of Black officeholders			
1(Freedmen Office)	0.81	0.84	1.25
	(0.20)	(0.21)	(0.31)
Control mean	0.43	0.64	0.64
R^2	0.34	0.35	0.45
Observations	884	699	699
State FE and core controls	Yes	Yes	Yes
Matched sample	No	Yes	Yes
Reweighted	No	No	Yes

Notes: This table reports estimates from regressions of Black political outcomes on an indicator for the county having any Freedmen's Bureau field office, state fixed effects, and the core control variables listed in panel A of Table 1. Columns 2 and 3 are limited to a sample of similar counties matched on these core variables. Column 3 applies inverse propensity score weighting. The outcome in panel A is the Black male voter registration rate (1867 to 1869), constructed as the number of registered voters divided by one-fourth the 1860 Black population (to account for the fact that only adult men could register to vote). The outcome in panel B is the number of Black officeholders elected in Reconstruction. Note that voter registration data is not available for all counties (see Supplemental Appendix B.1 for details). Heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors are reported in parentheses.

increased the Black voter registration rate by 18 percentage points. Results are somewhat smaller but still sizable when we limit the analysis to the sample of matched counties (13 percentage points; column 2) and when using our preferred approach of also adjusting for differences between treated and control counties using inverse propensity score weights (13 percentage points; column 3). Our preferred estimate amounts to 17 percent of the control county mean.[32]

The increase in Black political participation was accompanied by an increase in representation. Table 3, panel B examines effects on the number of Black political officeholders elected during Reconstruction (over 80 percent of whom entered office before 1872). All specifications point to a sizable increase in the number of Black officeholders, with our preferred estimate in column 3 implying that the existence of a Freedmen's Bureau office translated into an extra 1.2 elected officials in each county, which is roughly twice as large as the control group mean of 0.6.

The increase in Black voter registration is a natural explanation for the increase in the Republican vote share, as the vast majority of Black voters supported the Republican Party at this time (Foner 2014). In turn, higher participation of Black voters is an explanation for the increased rate of officeholding by Black politicians

[32] We find no effect of the Freedmen's Bureau on the White voter registration rate (point estimate from our preferred approach is 0.004, with a standard error of 0.02). This suggests that White individuals did not increase their political engagement in state constitutional conventions in response to bureau-induced increases in Black individuals' political power.

and officials. While these improvements in political representation were likely to be valuable to Black individuals, they may have spurred changes that were used to motivate backlash. Logan (2020a) shows that Black politicians during Reconstruction increased per capita tax revenue (and also increased Black literacy and land tenancy), and Logan (2023) shows that tax increases translated into violence against Black politicians. Motivated by this evidence, we turn to a direct and comprehensive examination of whether the Freedmen's Bureau was associated with changes in violence against Black people.

V. Results: Racial Backlash

This section examines whether the political progress fostered by the bureau was met with racial backlash. We begin by providing evidence that counties with a bureau field office had elevated levels of violence against Black citizens in the nineteenth century, including the years after the bureau ended its operations. Additional analyses show that racial backlash extended even into the twentieth century.

A. *Short-Run Racial Violence*

Measuring racial violence during this period is particularly difficult because many Southern White officeholders worked to undermine the civil rights of Black individuals, many Southern White citizens either implicitly or explicitly supported such violence, and modern systems to record vital statistics and crime did not exist. We address this challenge by compiling a variety of different measures, each of which has its own strengths and weaknesses.

We begin by examining media mentions of lynchings during this period, using data from newspapers.com. This approach is appealing because we can measure lynching reports *before* the opening of the Freedmen's Bureau, which enables us to use our event-study and related difference-in-differences specifications. We use data covering 1860–1864 as the pretreatment period and 1865–1900 for the posttreatment period. The key outcome of interest is a county-by-year measure of the rate of newspaper pages mentioning the keyword "lynching."

Table 4 shows that reports of lynchings were higher from 1865–1900 in counties with a bureau field office. The estimate in column 1 implies that a field office led to 0.6 additional mentions of "lynching" per 100 pages of newspaper stories, which is a 44 percent increase relative to the control group mean of 1.4. When estimating separate effects for the earlier and later periods of this time, we see that both periods have increased mentions of lynching in treated areas. The coefficient is almost three times larger in the later period, but the period-specific control mean also rises over time from 0.5 lynchings per 100 pages for 1865–1882 to 2.2 lynchings for 1883–1900, so the effect size relative to the control mean is larger in the earlier period. Figure 4 shows results from the more flexible event-study specification. Notably, the increase in reported lynchings begins shortly after the bureau is created and is positive in nearly every year after 1865. While lynchings increased over time in control counties, they increased by more in counties with a field office (Supplemental Appendix Figure A6).

Of course, newspaper mentions of lynchings suffer from several shortcomings, including the issue that they could report on violence in other locations or periods

TABLE 4—IMPACTS ON NEWSPAPER REPORTS OF LYNCHINGS, DIFFERENCE-IN-DIFFERENCE ESTIMATES

	Lynching report rate per 100 pages	
	(1)	(2)
Post '65–'00 × 1(Freedmen Office)	0.61	
	(0.16)	
Post '65–'82 × 1(Freedmen Office)		0.33
		(0.15)
Post '83–'00 × 1(Freedmen Office)		0.91
		(0.28)
County FE	Yes	Yes
Control mean	1.38	1.38
R^2	0.35	0.36
Observations	4,313	4,313

Notes: This table reports estimates from a difference-in-difference specification in which the rate of newspaper reports of lynchings (100 times the number of pages on which the term is found, divided by the total number of newspaper pages) is regressed on interactions between the county having any Freedmen's Bureau field office and indicators for being in a posttreatment period (defined as 1865–1900 in column 1 and separated as 1865–1882 and 1883–1900 in column 2), the 1865–1882 and 1883–1900 period indicators, interactions between these period indicators and the core controls listed in panel A of Table 1, and county fixed effects. Regressions are weighted by the ATT weights constructed from a logit regression of a county having a Freedmen's Bureau field office on state fixed effects and the core controls. The pretreatment period is January 1, 1860 to December 31, 1864. Control mean is calculated over all years. Note that newspaper data is not available for all counties (see Supplemental Appendix B.1 for details). Sample is limited to counties with at least 15 years of non-missing newspaper data. Heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors clustered at the county level are reported in parentheses.

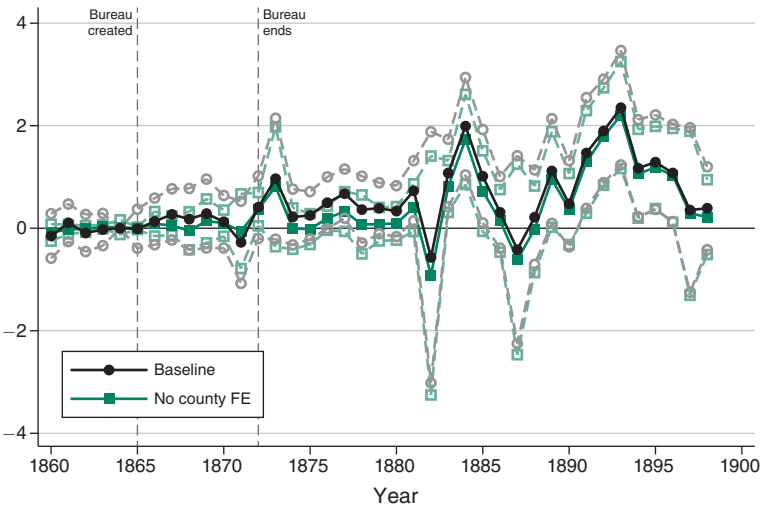


FIGURE 4. IMPACTS ON NEWSPAPER-BASED MENTIONS OF LYNCHINGS

Notes: This figure reports event-study estimates of the impacts of having at least one Freedmen's Bureau field office on county-level rates of newspaper mentions of lynching (100 times the number of pages on which the term lynching is found divided by the total number of newspaper pages). The baseline results are based on a regression that includes interactions between the county having any Freedmen's Bureau field office and year indicators, year indicators, interactions between year indicators and the core controls listed in panel A of Table 1, and county fixed effects. The omitted reference year is 1864. The figure also shows results from a specification in which county fixed effects are excluded and there is no omitted reference year. All regressions are weighted by the ATT weights constructed from a logit regression of a county having a Freedmen's Bureau field office on state fixed effects and the core controls. The dashed lines surrounding the point estimates represent the 95 percent confidence interval based on standard errors clustered at the county level. Sample is limited to counties with at least 15 years of non-missing newspaper data.

of time. They also may be valenced differently across areas (e.g., condoning versus reporting on the acts).[33] In Table 5, we present results from several alternative measures of racial violence. Because these data only exist after the opening of the Freedmen's Bureau, we estimate cross-sectional models for this analysis.

During the height of the bureau's operations, agents collected detailed reports of murders and other violent crimes against Black citizens, an outcome that we begin with in panel A as it is our earliest cross-sectional measure in the post-Civil War period. These reports capture the broader types of terrorism enacted against Black residents, beyond the narrow category of lynching captured in the Project HAL and Seguin and Rigby (2019a,b) datasets (see footnote 17). While bureau agents received and investigated reports of violence in surrounding areas, a caveat to this analysis is that bureau agents may have been more likely to record violence in areas with bureau offices.[34] Across specifications, we see a large and significant increase in this measure of violence, with about 1.3 extra acts of violence in treated counties, reflecting an 80 percent increase over control counties.

Panel B shows that attacks on Black schools between 1865 and 1878 were higher in counties with bureau offices. The estimated treatment effect from our preferred specification is an increase of 0.7 attacks, which is almost twice as large as the control group mean and significant at the 1 percent level. In interpreting this result, it is important to note that educational opportunities for Black Americans were limited prior to the Civil War due to state laws that forbade the creation of institutions to educate slaves and harsh punishments frequently pursued by slave owners (Woodson 1919). Against this backdrop, the creation of schools for Black individuals—which was spearheaded by the Freedmen's Bureau—represented a highly visible change in the social status of Black individuals.

We next consider a measure of institutional racial violence: death penalties executed under civil authority between 1865 and 1900. Panel C shows a significant increase of roughly 0.53 executions between 1865 and 1900, a 71 percent increase over the control mean.[35] To complement our newspaper-based analysis of lynching, panel D presents results for investigated lynchings between 1882 and 1900. Our preferred estimate shows that counties with a bureau field office experienced 0.4 additional lynchings from 1882–1900, a 27 percent increase over the control county mean.

[33] Supplemental Appendix Figure B1 shows examples of both of these types of issues.

[34] The historical record suggests that bureau agents did record reports of violent crimes from other counties. S. E. Melcher, the superintendent for LaGrange, Tennessee, wrote: "Complaints come in daily from the adjoining counties of Miss. of robbery, assaults &c, on the persons of Freedmen. Not less than one hundred and fifty have le[f]t Tippah and Marshall Co.'s, Miss. within the past week and came into Tenn. And all with their story." (National Archives Microfilm Publication M999, Roll 34, "Reports of Outrages, Riots and Murders," January 15, 1866–August 12, 1868).

[35] An open question is whether the effects on violence were higher during or immediately after the bureau operated. We examine this by measuring the number of Black school attacks and Black executions in the years prior to when the bureau was effectively defunded (1865–1869) and the immediately following years (1870–1878). If effects on our measures simply reflect better documentation of violence by bureau agents, then we expect to see impacts only during the bureau's years of operations. More substantively, if violence was carried out instrumentally to stall Black progress, then we may also see higher violence during bureau operations. At the same time, there are also reasons to expect the opposite pattern. Bureau agents may have deterred violence if potential perpetrators feared a higher likelihood of punishment. While we cannot disentangle these mechanisms, we find evidence suggesting that impacts on both measures of violence were substantial during bureau operations and increased after defunding (Supplemental Appendix Table A3). These results are consistent with real impacts of the bureau on violence that grew in the bureau's absence.

Table 5—Impacts on Racial Violence Outcomes, OLS and Matched Sample Estimates

	(1)	(2)	(3)
Panel A. Number of crimes against freedmen (1865–1868)			
1(Freedmen Office)	1.24	1.27	1.35
	(0.43)	(0.46)	(0.47)
Control mean	1.23	1.68	1.68
R^2	0.14	0.12	0.16
Observations	691	549	549
Panel B. Number of Black school attacks (1865–1878)			
1(Freedmen Office)	0.47	0.45	0.67
	(0.13)	(0.14)	(0.17)
Control mean	0.30	0.38	0.38
R^2	0.15	0.16	0.24
Observations	884	699	699
Panel C. Number of Black executions (1865–1900)			
1(Freedmen Office)	0.48	0.47	0.53
	(0.14)	(0.13)	(0.15)
Control mean	0.61	0.76	0.76
R^2	0.26	0.26	0.32
Observations	884	699	699
Panel D. Number of Black lynchings recorded (1882–1900)			
1(Freedmen Office)	0.30	0.28	0.35
	(0.17)	(0.18)	(0.18)
Control mean	1.09	1.32	1.32
R^2	0.25	0.24	0.26
Observations	884	699	699
Panel E. Nineteenth-century violence/hate index			
1(Freedmen Office)	0.32	0.31	0.39
	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.07)
Control SD	0.53	0.58	0.58
R^2	0.34	0.33	0.46
Observations	884	699	699
State FE and core controls	Yes	Yes	Yes
Matched sample	No	Yes	Yes
Reweighted	No	No	Yes

Notes: This table reports estimates from regressions of anti-Black violence outcomes on an indicator for the county having any Freedmen's Bureau office, state fixed effects, and the core control variables listed in panel A of Table 1. Columns 2 and 3 are limited to a sample of similar counties matched on these core variables. Column 3 applies inverse propensity score weighting. The outcome in panel A is the total number of instances of violence or crimes against freedmen (officially recorded as "outrages") reported to the Freedmen's Bureau (1865–1868). The outcome in panel B is the total number of attacks on Black schools (1865–1878). The outcome in panel C is the number of executions of Black individuals performed under civil authority from 1865 to 1900. The outcome in panel D is the total number of lynchings recorded between 1882 and 1900. The outcome in panel E is a summary index that equals the average of all non-missing outcome variables after they have been standardized using the mean and standard deviation of the control group in the column 3 sample. Note that data on violence or crimes against freedmen reported to the bureau is not available for all counties (see Supplemental Appendix B.1 for details). Heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors are reported in parentheses.

To summarize the impacts on violence, we construct a standardized index that combines all nineteenth century measures. The index is based on standardizing each of the preceding four violence measures using the control county mean and standard

deviation and constructing the average of the non-missing variables for each county. Panel E shows that we find that violence increases by 0.39 units of the index (0.67 standard deviations).

B. *Long-Run Racial Violence*

Next, we test whether the Freedmen's Bureau and the resulting backlash during Reconstruction had longer lasting effects. To do so, we first examine measures of anti-Black animus and violence that extend into the middle of the twentieth century. These measures cover a period that is well after the immediate backlash to Reconstruction, and they may be reflections and extensions of the attitudes and institutions built up in treated counties during that time.

First, we examine newly compiled measures of racially motivated killings of African Americans in the Jim Crow South beginning at the end of the Project HAL lynching data (1930) and extending to 1955. In Table 6, panel A examines how the presence of a Freedmen's Bureau field office affects this measure of racial violence more than 50 years later. Results are quite similar across specifications, with the final column showing that counties with a bureau field office had 0.9 more killings. The control group mean of this variable is 0.7 killings, which means that these effects amount to a 132 percent increase in racially motivated killings. In line with this increase in private racial violence, panel B shows that institutional racial violence in the form of executions also rose by 1.5 executions during the twentieth century, a 62 percent increase. These results suggest the increase in lynchings observed in treated counties in the late 1800s continued into the next century.

Our next set of results expands on our analysis of the rise of racial backlash by examining whether there was a greater amount of second and third wave KKK activity in counties with a bureau field office. The role of the first KKK in the anti-Black violence studied in Section VA has been well studied qualitatively, but the lack of historical data on their chapter locations precludes us from studying their role precisely. However, systematic data exist for later KKK waves, which allows us to investigate whether the historical presence of bureau offices had persistent effects on the propagation of organized racial hostility. Specifically, if the bureau contributed to lasting racial antagonism—perhaps by fueling resentment—these effects might manifest in heightened later-wave Klan activity. At its peak in 1924, the second KKK—at roughly 4 or 5 million members—had nearly 10 times the enrollment of the first KKK, before diminishing to 30,000 members by 1930 (Lay 2005; Baudouin 2011; Ang 2023b). The third iteration of the KKK emerged again in the 1950s and 1960s. While the third KKK was much smaller than the second KKK (roughly a third of the number of total chapters, and perhaps as few as 10,000 members), it had a significant presence in the South, with even more chapters than the second KKK in the geographic coverage of our data.

Table 6, panel C shows that counties with a bureau field office had 0.4 more second-wave KKK chapters, a 92 percent increase over the control group mean. This estimate is significant at the 1 percent level and robust to different specifications. A natural alternative is to use a binary indicator for whether the KKK had established a chapter by 1930 to match the way this outcome is parameterized in Ang (2023a, b). We find that a bureau field office increases the likelihood of a

Table 6—Impacts on Twentieth Century Black Killings, Black Executions, KKK Klaverns, and Confederate Monuments

	(1)	(2)	(3)
Panel A. Number of midcentury Black killings			
1(Freedmen Office)	0.94	0.91	0.90
	(0.51)	(0.48)	(0.31)
Control mean	0.63	0.68	0.68
R^2	0.09	0.09	0.13
Panel B. Number of Black executions (1900 to 2003)			
1(Freedmen Office)	1.47	1.35	1.48
	(0.52)	(0.51)	(0.51)
Control mean	1.97	2.39	2.39
R^2	0.20	0.20	0.25
Panel C. Number of second wave KKK klaverns			
1(Freedmen Office)	0.37	0.36	0.38
	(0.08)	(0.07)	(0.07)
Control mean	0.47	0.42	0.42
R^2	0.18	0.21	0.24
Panel D. Number of third wave KKK klaverns			
1(Freedmen Office)	0.40	0.39	0.47
	(0.12)	(0.12)	(0.13)
Control mean	0.50	0.60	0.60
R^2	0.21	0.21	0.24
Panel E. Number of Confederate monuments			
1(Freedmen Office)	1.17	1.10	1.42
	(0.30)	(0.31)	(0.43)
Control mean	1.41	1.65	1.65
R^2	0.24	0.23	0.27
Panel F. Twentieth-century violence/hate index			
1(Freedmen Office)	0.47	0.45	0.49
	(0.12)	(0.12)	(0.09)
Control SD	0.68	0.61	0.61
R^2	0.22	0.21	0.29
Observations	884	699	699
State FE and core controls	Yes	Yes	Yes
Matched sample	No	Yes	Yes
Reweighted	No	No	Yes

Notes: This table reports estimates from regressions of twentieth century outcomes on an indicator for the county having any Freedmen's Bureau field office, state fixed effects, and the core control variables listed in panel A of Table 1. Columns 2 and 3 are limited to a sample of similar counties matched on these core variables. Column 3 applies inverse propensity score weighting. The outcome in panel A is the number of Black killings reported in a county in the CRRJ data (1930–1955). Panel B is the number of executions of Black people performed under civil authority from 1900 to 2003. Panel C is the number of second-wave KKK klaverns ever established in a county from 1915 to 1942. Panel D is the number of third-wave KKK klaverns in the 1960s. Panel E is the number of Confederate monuments erected in a county. The outcome in panel F is a summary index that equals the average of all non-missing outcome variables after they have been standardized using the mean and standard deviation of the control group in the column 3 sample. Heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors are reported in parentheses.

klavern by 17 percentage points, which is around 61 percent of the control group mean (panel A of Supplemental Appendix Table A4). While not directly comparable due to Ang's (2023a, b) focus on the entire United States, this is roughly 26 percent

of his main instrumental variable estimate of the effect of screenings of *The Birth of a Nation*. Panel D of Table 6 shows that counties with a bureau field office have about 0.5 more third wave KKK klaverns, a 77 percent increase over the control mean. Again, estimates are statistically significant and robust across specifications. We continue to see a positive effect when using a binary measure for the presence of any third wave KKK klavern (panel B of Supplemental Appendix Table A4). These results show the remarkable persistence of the backlash almost a hundred years after the operation of the Freedmen's Bureau.

In panel E of Table 6, we examine the presence of Confederate monuments in a county as another long-run expression of racial attitudes, following Ang (2023a, b) and also studied by Bazzi et al. (2023). We find a substantial effect of bureau office locations on the establishment of these monuments, with column 3 showing an additional 1.4 monuments, almost doubling the number found in control counties. Panel F summarizes all of the impacts by using a standardized index that combines all of these long-run outcomes. Our preferred estimate indicates that the bureau increased twentieth century racial violence by 0.81 standard deviations.

C. *Intergenerational Mobility*

Finally, we study outcomes of young adults from the Opportunity Atlas (Chetty et al. 2018) to test whether the lasting legacy of the backlash still resonates in the economic and social outcomes of the present day. Using our state fixed effects and matching-style specifications, we compare children born between 1978 and 1983 who were raised in treated and control counties.[36] In Table 7, panel A examines measures of intergenerational mobility for children born to parents whose income placed them at the twenty-fifth percentile of the nationwide distribution. We find that children raised in counties that long ago had a Freedmen's Bureau field office face a reduction of 0.4 percentiles in their later-life income rank.[37] Relative to the control group mean income rank (38.3 percentiles), this is roughly a 1 percent drop and amounts to around $1,000 of household income per year. Panel B shows a 0.4 percentage point increase in incarceration, roughly a 7 percent increase relative to the control mean.[38,39] In particular for the interpretation of these results, we note that a change in the composition of residents is one channel through which the bureau offices could have long-run effects. Despite the bureau only operating for a few years, the backlash produced and upheld institutions that had detrimental effects on children roughly a century later.

[36] The underlying sample is not restricted to individuals who spent their entire childhood in these counties. The Opportunity Atlas weights individuals' outcomes based on the amount of time they spend in each county to produce an exposure-adjusted estimate of economic mobility.

[37] One benchmark for this 0.4 percentile impact of the bureau can be obtained from estimates of the effects of racial segregation on upward mobility. Chyn, Haggag, and Stuart (2022) use an instrumental variable strategy based on historical railroad placement (Ananat 2011) and find that a one standard deviation increase in contemporaneous racial segregation reduces upward mobility by 4 percentiles.

[38] The Opportunity Atlas also provides a measure of teenage pregnancy (based on whether IRS records indicate that a woman claimed a dependent when they were between the ages of 13 and 19) as an additional long-run outcome. We find small, positive point estimates for this outcome (indicating increases in teen fertility) although these are not statistically significant in our preferred specification (Supplemental Appendix Table A5).

[39] The impacts on intergenerational mobility and incarceration are driven by effects on Black individuals (Supplemental Appendix Table A6).

Table 7—Impacts on Long-Run Opportunity, OLS and Matched Sample Estimates

	(1)	(2)	(3)
Panel A. Upward mobility (1978–1983 cohorts)			
1(Freedmen Office)	−0.005	−0.004	−0.004
	(0.002)	(0.002)	(0.002)
Control mean	0.39	0.38	0.38
R^2	0.52	0.45	0.46
Panel B. Incarceration rate (1978–1983 cohorts)			
1(Freedmen Office)	0.004	0.004	0.004
	(0.001)	(0.001)	(0.002)
Control mean	0.05	0.05	0.05
R^2	0.30	0.25	0.27
Observations	884	699	699
State FE and core controls	Yes	Yes	Yes
Matched sample	No	Yes	Yes
Reweighted	No	No	Yes

Notes: This table reports estimates from regressions of long-run outcomes (mobility and incarceration during adulthood, taken from the Opportunity Atlas) on an indicator for the county having any Freedmen's Bureau office, state fixed effects, and the core control variables listed in panel A of Table 1. Columns 2 and 3 are limited to a sample of similar counties matched on these core variables. Column 3 applies inverse propensity score weighting. The outcome in panel A measures upward mobility for children born to parents in the twenty-fifth percentile of the national income distribution. More specifically, it is the average later-life rank in the nationwide income distribution for children born from 1978–1983 using IRS administrative records on income from 2014–2015 (when the respective cohorts were aged 31–37). The outcome in panel B is the incarceration rate for men, based on the 2010 census short form. Heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors are reported in parentheses.

VI. Robustness

This section presents several exercises to assess the sensitivity of our results. We begin with concerns related to the event-study approach. While there is no evidence of detectable differences in outcomes between treated and control counties prior to the bureau's creation, a potential issue is that posttreatment differences could partly reflect shocks to social or economic conditions unrelated to the bureau's impact. We conclude with a discussion of additional sensitivity analysis for our cross-sectional estimates.

A. *Event-Study Tests*

We begin by taking three approaches to address concerns about time-varying confounds. First, we explore the potential importance of federal troop levels in a county. Prior historical work highlights that the Northern military was an important institution in the South during the Reconstruction era (Downs 2015a), and the bureau often coordinated with the military.[40] That said, the historical record also emphasizes that the bureau had its own independent impacts. For example, in an 1866 meeting with federal generals sent to the South by President Johnson, a large

[40] Within political science, troop presence has been correlated with measures of political and social outcomes of Black Americans (Chacón, Jensen, and Yntiso 2021; Stewart and Kitchens 2021).

crowd of nearly 1,000 freedmen in Wilmington, North Carolina, unanimously told the military leaders that, if forced to choose, they would prefer to have the bureau remain in the South over the Army (Foner 2014). To empirically clarify the role of the military for our results, we augment our event-study specification with controls for the median number of Union troops stationed in a county during 1865–1872, the bureau's years of operation. This is achieved by including interactions between this troop measure and a full set of time indicators in equation (1).

Second, we examine the influence of the Freedman's Savings Bank, a distinct Reconstruction institution that also aimed at improving conditions for newly-emancipated Black Americans. Chartered by Congress on March 3, 1865, by 1874 the bank grew to encompass over 100,000 accounts across 17 states. While Stein and Yannelis (2020) estimate positive short-term effects of the bank on Black individuals' education, employment, and income, Celerier and Tak (2024) argue these effects cannot be separated from the positive selection of bank branches into areas with higher Black wealth. The Freedman's Bank also interacted with other social institutions, including the use of Freedmen's Bureau school teachers for outreach to gather bank deposits. Given the entanglement between the bureau and the bank, we take a similar approach as we do with studying troops. In particular, we use data from Celerier and Tak (2024) which contains the location of the 28 bank branches whose registers were preserved and add interactions between an indicator for a county having a bank branch and the full set of time indicators. As with the robustness check for troops, we acknowledge that the bureau may have influenced the location of bank branches or the number of bank depositors in an area, so that controlling for location of bank branches is a potential "bad control" (Angrist and Pischke 2009; Montgomery, Nyhan, and Torres 2018).[41]

Our third event-study exercise focuses on the potential role of other confounding posttreatment shocks as measured by demographic or economic conditions. We follow standard approaches and augment equation (1) by including time-varying measures of county-level population and economic conditions (i.e., the log of total population, the log of manufacturing employment, the log of the total value of manufacturing, or the log of the total value of farms) from the Decennial Census.[42] Our main interest is examining whether the inclusion of these additional time-varying measures affects the bureau event-study estimates.

We find reassuring results from these three exercises for electoral outcomes in Supplemental Appendix Figure A7. The figure reproduces our main estimates (thick black lines) alongside the bureau event-study coefficients from the augmented models. The bureau impacts from models that include troop measures (teal squares) or bank branch locations (red diamonds) are nearly unchanged. The figure similarly shows that our results are even less sensitive to the inclusion of time-varying county-level characteristics.

[41] The unconditional correlation of bureau offices with the presence of a bank branch is modest at 0.05, as is the correlation with the total number of depositors at 0.09. After implementing the matching and weighting, these relationships are insignificant.

[42] To do this, we associate each election with the county-level characteristics from the most recent previous Decennial Census. For example, we use the 1870 census county characteristics for all elections that occurred during the 1870s. Of course, it is possible that during the posttreatment years some of these variables were influenced by the presence of a Freedmen's Bureau field office, and thus constitute "bad controls." Given this, we interpret our results from this robustness analysis cautiously and do not include time-varying controls in our primary specifications.

We provide similar sensitivity results for our analysis of the newspaper-based measure of lynchings in Supplemental Appendix Table A7. Again, columns 2 and 3 demonstrate that the results for the bureau impacts are not substantively affected by including interactions between the posttreatment period indicators and the federal troop measure or the Freedman's Bank branch indicator. Columns 4–7 provide additional reassuring evidence that our lynching results are robust to including time-varying measures of economic and demographic measures.

Finally, we conclude this section by augmenting our event-study specification to include an expanded set of baseline controls. While equation (1) includes the seven core controls listed in Table 1, it is possible this does not adequately adjust for cross-county differences in the event-study estimates. Reassuringly, we obtain estimates that are similar when adjusting for *all* of the 1860 characteristics in Table 1 in several flexible specifications (Supplemental Appendix Figures A8 and A9).

B. *Cross-Sectional Tests*

We also conduct related robustness exercises for our cross-sectional estimates. First, we estimate several augmented models. To assess the importance of the US Army presence, we add the troop measure as an additional control variable in the propensity score and regression adjustment steps. Next, we augment the model to include the Freedman's Bank branch indicator in a similar manner. We also use the full set of controls listed in both panels A and B of Table 1. The results are quite similar from all of these augmented models, which provides further reassurance on the validity of our results (Supplemental Appendix Table A8). Second, we show that our results are similar when dropping individual states from the analysis, which reduces the concern that some other policy overlaps with the Freedmen's Bureau in an unaccounted-for manner (Hoehn-Velasco, Penglase, Pesko, and Shahid 2024) (Supplemental Appendix Tables A9 and A10). Third, we find little evidence that control counties with a field office nearby had different outcomes than counties where a field office was farther away—consistent with a lack of spillover effects on adjacent counties (Supplemental Appendix Table A11). Fourth, the differences in cross-sectional outcomes between counties with and without a bureau field office are apparent throughout their distributions, which lowers the concern about outliers driving our results (Supplemental Appendix Figures A11 and A12).

VII. Mechanisms and Heterogeneity

In this section, we provide additional evidence related to the mechanisms that could underlie our results for the effects of the Freedmen's Bureau. We begin by using census data to estimate impacts on additional outcomes that could have generated political or social responses in our setting. Next, we conduct heterogeneity analyses to shed light on additional channels that could drive the racial backlash that we document.

A. *Census Outcomes*

The improved opportunities for Black Americans facilitated by the Freedmen's Bureau may have spurred shifts in Black demographic outcomes that subsequently

triggered increased White hostility in treated areas. The role of White fears of even modest Black progress or demographic expansion threatening their status has long been discussed in political science, most notably with Key (1949). In sociology, Blumer (1958) emphasized relative group position as a source of prejudice, a topic covered within stratification economics (Darity 2022), as noted in Section I.

Table 8 studies Black demographic shifts observed in Decennial Censuses.[43] We begin by examining the effects on the share of the population that is Black in column 1. Our motivation is that even small increases in the Black population share could trigger the "symbolic potency" of racial threat (Key 1949). After finding no evidence of pre-trends in the 1840 and 1850 censuses, we see that relative to the 1860 census, the Black population share is 1.9 percentage points higher in treated counties in 1880 (6 percent of the control mean), before declining in magnitude for 1890 and 1900. This elevated Black population share may have motivated the nineteenth century increase in racial violence. However, by 1910 there is no longer evidence of a differential change in the Black population share in counties with a bureau field office.[44] This finding suggests that backlash in the twentieth century was not a response to a contemporaneous increase in the Black population share.

Another potential catalyst of White backlash is the prospect for improved economic outcomes and dignity signaled by improved schooling for Black children and literacy for adults. We examine these outcomes in light of the bureau's efforts to develop and promote schools that served children, and in some cases adults, as recognized by historians (Du Bois 1903, 1935; Taylor 1924; Foner 2014).[45,46] For children, our dependent variables for school attendance and literacy are calculated for individuals aged 5–19, while adult literacy is calculated using all individuals over age 19. We see an increase in school attendance of 1.5 percentage points (6 percent of the control group mean) in counties with a bureau field office in 1880. The effect is also apparent from 1900–1920. Evidence of positive impacts after 1870 is not surprising because many schools created by the bureau were operated by charitable organizations or integrated in the public education system after its closure in 1872 (Vaughn 2014). Impacts on literacy rates of Black children (column 3) are similar, while there are smaller-in-magnitude, but often imprecisely estimated, positive impacts for adults (column 4). A key takeaway is that the improved educational opportunities for the Black community could have contributed to the observed backlash in both the short and longer terms.[47]

[43] A caveat for our analysis of the census outcomes measured in 1870 is that prior research suggests that this year suffered from underenumeration (Steckel 1991), which could affect our results if underenumeration rates differed between counties with and without a bureau field office.

[44] This finding holds in subsequent decades.

[45] Du Bois (1935) notes that Black adult freedmen sought to learn to read by attending night schools. As demonstrated in Supplemental Appendix Figure A13, the archival records indicate that buildings financed by the bureau were often used as night schools.

[46] Our aim is to use our matched-sample event-study approach to build on the descriptive findings from Troost (2006) who previously examined the correlation between the presence of bureau schools within a county and schooling outcomes using the 1870 census.

[47] We also find evidence that Black individuals in counties with a bureau field office were less likely to work as a farmer or farm laborer and more likely to work in domestic service in the medium run (Supplemental Appendix Table A12).

Table 8—Impacts on Black Population and Education Outcomes, Event-Study Results

	Black population share (1)	Black child school attendance rate (2)	Black child literacy rate (3)	Black adult literacy rate (4)
1840 × 1(Freedmen Office)	0.003			
	(0.006)			
1850 × 1(Freedmen Office)	0.004	0.000	0.000	−0.005
	(0.006)	(0.007)	(0.006)	(0.009)
1870 × 1(Freedmen Office)	0.011	0.007	0.004	−0.002
	(0.006)	(0.007)	(0.006)	(0.009)
1880 × 1(Freedmen Office)	0.019	0.015	0.017	0.013
	(0.006)	(0.007)	(0.006)	(0.009)
1890 × 1(Freedmen Office)	0.016			
	(0.006)			
1900 × 1(Freedmen Office)	0.012	0.013	0.020	0.014
	(0.006)	(0.007)	(0.006)	(0.009)
1910 × 1(Freedmen Office)	0.009	0.014	0.019	0.015
	(0.006)	(0.007)	(0.006)	(0.009)
1920 × 1(Freedmen Office)	0.003	0.023	0.015	0.011
	(0.006)	(0.007)	(0.006)	(0.009)
Observations	6,209	4,887	4,887	4,888
R^2	0.93	0.94	0.93	0.91
Control mean	0.34	0.23	0.22	0.30

Notes: This table reports estimates of an event-study specification in which the indicated dependent variable (Black population share, Black school attendance rate for children ages 5–19, literacy rate for Black children ages 5–19, literacy rate for Black adults ages 20+) is regressed on interactions between the county having any Freedmen's Bureau field office and year indicators, interactions between year indicators and state indicators, interactions between year indicators and the core controls listed in panel A of Table 1, and county fixed effects. Regressions are weighted by the ATT weights constructed from a logit regression of a county having a Freedmen's Bureau field office on state fixed effects and the core controls. The Black school attendance rate and Black literacy rates are not measurable for 1840 or 1890. For 1850 and 1860, we construct the Black school attendance rate by assuming that all Black children who were slaves did not attend school (i.e., individuals who were slaves contribute only to the denominator of the school attendance rate), and we do the same for the Black literacy rates. Robust standard errors clustered at the county level are reported in parentheses.

B. *Determinants of Backlash and Racial Violence*

Was backlash a response to *realized* Black or Republican political gains, or was it also present in areas that did not see these advances? Prior and contemporaneous work has shown that racial violence was heightened during this period in areas that elected Black officials (Logan 2023) and Republican politicians (Testa and Williams 2023). We turn to heterogeneity analysis to study this question.

In Table 9, we examine heterogeneity in both nineteenth and twentieth century racial violence impacts in areas that did or did not elect any Black officials and in those that experienced more or less substantial declines in the Democratic vote share between 1860 and 1872, the last year of the bureau's operations. Columns 3 and 4 show heterogeneity comparing treatment effects in areas that elected any Black officials (278 counties, of which 179 were treated) and those that did not elect any

Table 9—Heterogeneity in Impacts by Initial Political Progress and Racial Violence

	Control		Black officeholder elected?		Decrease in Democratic vote share, 1860–1872		Nineteenth-century violence/hate index	
	SD	Baseline	Yes	No	High	Low	High	Low
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Nineteenth century	0.58	0.39	0.50	0.12	0.53	0.20	0.48	0.04
Violence/hate index		(0.07)	(0.11)	(0.06)	(0.11)	(0.07)	(0.10)	(0.02)
p-value, difference			0.003		0.008		0.000	
R^2		0.44	0.56	0.21	0.48	0.41	0.59	0.86
Twentieth century	0.61	0.49	0.75	0.21	0.63	0.30	0.70	0.15
Violence/hate index		(0.09)	(0.17)	(0.07)	(0.14)	(0.09)	(0.15)	(0.05)
p-value, difference			0.003		0.051		0.000	
R^2		0.28	0.38	0.15	0.30	0.45	0.35	0.26
Observations		699	278	421	347	348	348	351

Notes: This table reports estimates from regressions of two index outcomes on an indicator for the county having any Freedmen's Bureau office, state fixed effects, and the core control variables listed in panel A of Table 1. The nineteenth-century violence/hate index consists of the number of instances of violence or crimes reported to the Freedmen's Bureau from 1865–1868, the number of Black school attacks from 1865–1878, the number of Black executions from 1865–1900, and the number of Black lynchings recorded from 1882–1900. The twentieth-century violence/hate index consists of the number of midcentury Black killings, the number of Black executions from 1900 to 2003, the number of second-wave KKK klaverns, the number of third-wave KKK klaverns, and the number of Confederate monuments. We construct the summary indices by taking the average of all non-missing outcome variables after they have been standardized using the mean and standard deviation of the control group in the matched sample. All results also apply inverse propensity score weighting. Column 1 reports the standard deviation of the dependent variable for the control group of the estimation sample in column 2. Column 2 reports results from our baseline specification. Columns 3 and 4 split the sample based on whether the county elected a Black officeholder during Reconstruction (278 counties) or did not (421 counties). Columns 5 and 6 split the sample based on whether the decrease in the Democratic vote in presidential elections between 1860 to 1872 was above or below the sample median of 5.1 percentage points. Columns 7 and 8 split the sample based on whether the nineteenth-century violence/hate index was above or below the sample median. Heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors are reported in parentheses.

Black officials (421 counties, of which 162 were treated). Columns 5 and 6 show heterogeneity by a median split in the decrease in the Democratic vote share.[48] An important caveat for these results is that we condition each analysis based on a posttreatment outcome.

We estimate impacts on the summary index measures presented previously to both increase power and reduce the number of hypotheses tested. Two sets of results emerge from this analysis. First, we see greater nineteenth and twentieth century racial violence in areas with greater realized Black and Republican empowerment. For example, we find increases in the nineteenth-century violence index of 0.86 and 0.21 standard deviations in areas that did versus did not elect a Black official, respectively (calculated as the effects of 0.50 and 0.12 divided by the standard deviation of 0.58). Second, there remain large and significant increases in racial violence even in areas that did *not* have increases in realized Black and Republican progress. Areas that experienced, on average, an increase in the Democratic vote share

[48] The median change in the Democratic vote share is a 5.1 percentage point drop. Among counties with an above-median decrease (column 5), the Democratic vote share fell by 23.6 percentage points on average. Among the other half of counties, the Democratic vote share *rose* by 16.1 percentage points on average.

still saw heightened racial violence in counties treated with a bureau office (e.g., increases of 0.34 and 0.48 standard deviations in nineteenth- and twentieth-century violence respectively). Overall, these results suggest that political progress was not a necessary condition for racial backlash, but such progress did trigger additional backlash.

A related question is whether the twentieth-century violence and hate that emerged in response to the bureau was concentrated in the same counties that saw higher rates of violence in the nineteenth century. To explore this issue, columns 7 and 8 of Table 9 split the sample based on whether the nineteenth-century violence and hate index was above or below the sample median. We find that the relationship between the Freedmen's Bureau and racial hate in the twentieth century is much stronger in counties with high levels of racial violence in the nineteenth century. This evidence suggests that the nineteenth-century violent backlash to the Freedmen's Bureau might have triggered lasting changes in racial hate and the degree to which such hate is violently expressed in local areas.

C. *Intensity of Freedmen's Bureau Personnel*

Field offices varied in the number of Freedmen's Bureau agents who were assigned to each location. This staffing variation has the potential to shed light on the degree to which the effects on political progress and racial backlash were driven by the presence of the bureau versus the intensity of its operations in an area. For example, a single agent could trigger racial backlash if White individuals responded to the symbolic presence of the federal government in their local community. Alternatively, backlash could be muted if the number of bureau agents was insufficient to support Black civic and legal rights. Ultimately, an analysis of how staffing levels correlate with bureau impacts sheds light on questions of state capacity and efficiency.

There are several challenges associated with characterizing the level of support received by a field office. The bureau was, in many senses, a public-private partnership, and we do not have a way to track the number of volunteers and staff from other organizations (e.g., the AMA and the Union League) who assisted in the mission of the bureau. However, we can use records from bureau state reports that detail office staff, including their full employment dates spanning all years of the bureau's operations. These records provide a list of 513 staff which can be linked to a subset of the treated counties in our analysis.[49] Supplemental Appendix C provides additional details on both the available data and challenges associated with quantifying bureau staffing using the archival records.

Table 10 presents heterogeneity analysis based on computing the bureau office staffing per 1,000 Black residents and splitting the sample based on the median value (equal to 0.38). In panel A, we examine impacts on presidential Republican and Democratic vote shares in the two groupings of years shown in Table 2, with column 3 repeating the same specifications in the sample of treated counties for which we observe staffing records. The estimated coefficients are similar to those

[49] We count the number of bureau employees in 1867 as it is a year that also has an Official Registers report (produced in odd years) and corresponds to the peak in the number of staff in the state reports.

Table 10—Heterogeneity in Impacts by Freedmen's Bureau Staff per Black Individual

	Control	Control		Freedmen's Bureau staff per capita (Black)		*p*-value, difference
	Mean (1)	SD (2)	Baseline (3)	High (4)	Low (5)	High versus low (6)
Panel A. Impacts on presidential vote shares						
Democratic vote share (1868–1872)	57.2	19.9	−4.4	−4.3	−3.8	0.8
			(1.4)	(1.7)	(1.7)	
R^2			0.46	0.40	0.46	
Republican vote share (1868–1872)	42.7	19.9	4.4	4.4	3.8	0.8
			(1.4)	(1.7)	(1.7)	
R^2			0.45	0.40	0.46	
Democratic vote share (1873–1900)	63.3	13.9	−0.5	−2.1	0.4	0.1
			(1.0)	(1.2)	(1.5)	
R^2			0.48	0.45	0.48	
Republican vote share (1873–1900)	32.1	15.1	1.0	2.7	−0.2	0.1
			(1.1)	(1.2)	(1.5)	
R^2			0.50	0.48	0.50	
Panel B. Impacts on summary indices						
Black political power index	−0.02	0.73	0.54	0.56	0.43	0.5
			(0.11)	(0.14)	(0.15)	
R^2			0.43	0.37	0.44	
Nineteenth-cen. violence/hate index	0.00	0.58	0.40	0.29	0.47	0.2
			(0.07)	(0.07)	(0.12)	
R^2			0.38	0.25	0.45	
Twentieth-cen. violence/hate index	0.00	0.61	0.46	0.44	0.44	1.0
			(0.08)	(0.10)	(0.10)	
R^2			0.36	0.27	0.34	
Observations			607	482	483	

Notes: This table reports estimates from regressions of the presidential vote shares (panel A) and summary index outcomes (panel B) on an indicator for the county having any Freedmen's Bureau office, state fixed effects, and the core control variables listed in panel A of Table 1. The Black political power index consists of the Black voter registration rate and the number of Black officeholders. The nineteenth-century violence/hate index consists of the number of instances of violence or crimes reported to the Freedmen's Bureau from 1865–1868, the number of Black school attacks from 1865–1878, the number of Black executions from 1865–1900, and the number of Black lynchings recorded from 1882–1900. The twentieth-century violence/hate index consists of the number of midcentury Black killings, the number of Black executions from 1900 to 2003, the number of second-wave KKK klaverns, the number of third-wave KKK klaverns, and the number of Confederate monuments. We construct the summary indices by taking the average of all non-missing outcome variables after they have been standardized using the mean and standard deviation of the control group in the matched sample. All results also apply inverse propensity score weighting. Columns 1 and 2 report the mean and standard deviation of the dependent variable for the control group of the estimation sample of column 3. Column 3 reports results from our baseline specification when limited to the subset of treatment counties (249) for which we observe complete information on the number of Freedmen's Bureau personnel in the National Archives and Records Administration (NARA) records (and the full set of overlapping control counties for a total sample of 607 versus 699 in Table 1). In column 4, we limit the set of treated counties to those with an above-median number of Freedmen's Bureau staff per Black resident of the county (as of 1860). In column 5, we repeat this exercise for treated counties at or below the median of Freedmen's Bureau staff per capita, which is 1 agent per 2,618 Black individuals. Column 6 reports the *p*-value on the null hypothesis that the estimates in columns 4 and 5 are equal. The control group remains constant across columns 3 to 5. Heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors are reported in parentheses.

for the full sample in Table 2. Columns 4 and 5 show that there are somewhat larger effects on vote shares in areas with greater staff support. Altogether these results suggest that the bureau had its largest political effects in areas with more official staffing support per capita.

Panel B of Table 10 examines the indices of our other primary outcomes.[50] Columns 4 and 5 show that areas with more staffing ended up with greater Black empowerment (0.77 versus 0.59 standard deviations). We estimate a smaller increase in nineteenth-century violence and hate in areas with more staff per capita (0.50 versus 0.81 standard deviations). Despite this, the last row finds similar increases in twentieth century racial violence.

Overall, these results suggest that offices with more staffing support were more effective in carrying out their goals. This benefited Black residents both by increasing empowerment and limiting (but not eliminating) violence in the nineteenth century. At the same time, our finding that offices with fewer staff still had significant impacts highlights that the presence of the bureau was sufficient to both advance Black political progress and trigger backlash. However, caution should be taken in interpreting these results, as staffing intensity was not randomly assigned.

VIII. Conclusion

In this paper, we study one of the most ambitious attempts by a government to reform long-standing institutions. Specifically, we examine the political and social impacts of the Freedmen's Bureau, an agency tasked with the broad mission of aiding and promoting the independence of former slaves. Our analysis shows that counties exposed to bureau field offices saw substantially increased Black political participation and representation, as well as vote share gains for the abolitionist Republican Party, in the years following the Civil War.

However, the counties treated with greater bureau exposure exhibited a swift and severe backlash against efforts to reform the preexisting political and social institutions that promoted White supremacy. Vote shares for the pro-slavery Democratic Party rebounded to their pre-Civil War levels by the end of the 1880s. Moreover, we find evidence of important social backlash in the form of elevated levels of violence enacted on the Black citizens of treated counties in the years during and after the closure of the bureau. Our concluding analysis shows a remarkable persistence of the harmful effects of this backlash, with higher rates of Ku Klux Klan activity in treated counties in the twentieth century, elevated levels of private and institutional racial violence, and lower rates of intergenerational mobility over a century after the closure of bureau offices.

These findings offer two main contributions. First, we relate to a literature that has theoretically and empirically sought to explain and quantify the persistence of institutions (Acemoglu and Robinson 2006, 2008; Martinez-Bravo, Mukherjee, and Stegmann 2017; Dell, Lane, and Querubin 2018). Indeed, the US South and its particular manifestation of White supremacy via slavery and Jim Crow laws has long been highlighted as an example of institutional persistence through varied means (e.g., de jure versus de facto power). Relative to prior work, our analysis goes beyond demonstrating the persistence of institutions. Instead, the data for our analysis permits study of the dynamics of a significant reform to established institutions. We find that reform efforts generated meaningful political and social progress

[50] For Black political power, we standardize the outcomes of Table 3.

when the Freedmen's Bureau operated and the federal government was committed to Reconstruction. This initial progress was accompanied by a significant degree of racial violence. After the federal government's commitment to reform lapsed, backlash and the spread of institutional mechanisms such as politically-motivated violence undermined and suppressed the initial progress. A leading explanation for both the short and longer-run backlash is that the federal government did not provide the sustained resources necessary to meet the enormous challenge of reshaping the South. In this sense, the experience of the US South differs from the radical reform associated with the French Revolution, which had lasting consequences on local areas (Acemoglu et al. 2011).

Second, our findings add clarity to historical debates on the extent and dynamics of social progress during the Reconstruction era. In the early 1900s, historians of the Dunning School described the Reconstruction period as "the darkest page in the saga of American history" because of the view that Black individuals were incapable of properly exercising the new political rights they received (Foner 2014, p. xxvii). Du Bois (1903, 1935) provided a more balanced view of the merits and limitations of social and political reforms launched after the end of slavery, although his work was largely ignored by the profession at the time. Revisionist work in the 1960s reinterpreted essentially every aspect of the Dunning School analysis and viewed Reconstruction as "a time of extraordinary social and political progress for Blacks" (Foner 2014, p. xx). Subsequent work in the 1970s and 1980s "questioned whether anything of enduring importance happened at all" during this time (Foner 2014, p. xxi). More recent scholarship by Foner (2014), which follows in the tradition of Du Bois, sees "Black participation in Southern public life after 1867 [as] the most radical development" and a "massive experiment in interracial democracy without precedent" (Foner 2014, p. xxiii). Motivated by these changing evaluations based on qualitative approaches, our quantitative analysis documents important intended and unintended consequences of the federal government's most prominent effort to reform Southern institutions and improve conditions for Black Americans during the Reconstruction era.

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